

KNOX CITY

written by

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EXT. EL DORADO MOTEL - KNOX CITY, TEXAS - DAWN - (2025)

A two-lane blacktop running flat out of the dark.

Headlights on it. A truck slowing. A sign half lit above it.

EL DORADO MOTEL.

The truck turns in. Twelve rooms in an L. A gravel lot.

The MOTEL CLERK, mid-fifties, gets out and crosses to the office in the blue light.

INT. EL DORADO MOTEL - OFFICE - DAWN - (2025)

He lets himself in.

Hits the lights.

He starts the coffee maker.

Counts the drawer against a slip of paper.

Turns a hand-lettered sign in the window.

OPEN.

He stands at the window with the first coffee.

No cars. A freight horn miles off south.

EXT. EL DORADO MOTEL - BREEZEWAY - MORNING - (2025)

The clerk works down the L with a trash bag.

Swaps the liner in the can by room 4.

Picks a beer bottle off the cracked cement. Drops it in.

He stops at room 7.

Yesterday's paper still rolled on the mat.

The window unit silent. The curtain shut tight.

He knocks.

He listens at the door.

Knocks harder.

He sorts the master off his ring of keys.

INT. ROOM 7 - EL DORADO MOTEL - CONTINUOUS - (2025)

The door swings in on dark.

Curtains drawn. The television is on, washing the walls blue.

On the TV, a morning show. Somebody on it is laughing.

MOTEL CLERK

Fuck.

RAY REDWINE, 73, beard-balding-beer-gut, on the bed.

One boot on.

On the bare foot the toenails are painted coral. Chipped.

At his throat a silk scarf, knotted small.

Vomit stains cover the bed. Beer bottles litter the floor.

The clerk stands in the doorway, trash bag still in hand.

The window unit kicks on, breathes air on the naked dead man.

The clerk backs out one step onto the walk way.

He looks down the empty breezeway.

INT. PEDIATRIC CARDIOLOGY OFFICE - WICHITA FALLS - DAY (1990)

A plastic heart in cutaway on the desk.

JEANNE REDWINE, 36, sits forward in her chair.

She holds the hand of their son, BEAU, 6.

The boy swings his legs under the chair. Short of the floor.

RAY, 38, sun-cured, a feed store cap in his lap.

A half step behind her chair.

Across the desk the CARDIOLOGIST studies a file.

On the wall a chart of a child's chest.

The boy gives up on his legs reaching the floor and starts a slow kick instead, heel against the chair leg. A small steady knock.

Nobody tells him to stop. The doctor lets it go like a clock he's used to.

CARDIOLOGIST

The echo come back about like we figured. The pressures are climbing on us. I'd hoped the new medication would buy more road than it has.

JEANNE

It's only been since Easter.

CARDIOLOGIST

I know it.

He closes the file.

Folds his hands on it like a man saying grace over bad news.

CARDIOLOGIST (CONT'D)

I'm going to say the word transplant now, and I want you to hear the whole sentence before your minds run off with the first word. Because the whole sentence is good news. Loma Linda. East of Los Angeles. It's where they're doing them.

JEANNE

How many of these they done?

CARDIOLOGIST

On a child his size? Six.

JEANNE

Six this year?

CARDIOLOGIST

Six.

The boy swings his legs.

JEANNE

And the six. How many of em are--

CARDIOLOGIST

Four are home with their mamas.

JEANNE

And the other two.

CARDIOLOGIST

One we lost on the table. One after, to a infection.

I'm not going to tell you different
than what is. You'd catch me at it
anyhow.

JEANNE

I would.

She writes the two down too. The ones that don't come home.
She writes those down same as the rest.

The doctor's eyes go to Ray.

RAY

What's a thing like that cost.

CARDIOLOGIST

More than your house. That's why
there's programs.

JEANNE

Will he make it to the end of the
month?

CARDIOLOGIST

I wouldn't be talking about
airplanes if I thought otherwise.

The boy has got hold of the plastic heart.

Opening it and closing it.

BEAU

Is this the size of mine?

CARDIOLOGIST

Yours is littler. About the size of
your fist there.

The boy makes a fist and considers it.

He holds the fist up to his own chest. Then up to Ray's
chest, comparing, like a man sizing lumber.

Ray lets him hold it there. Doesn't move.

BEAU

And they put a different one in?

CARDIOLOGIST

A stronger one. And you'll be
asleep the whole time, and your
mama will be right there when you
wake up.

BEAU
Whose was it?

CARDIOLOGIST
Somebody real generous.

The room grows quiet.

CARDIOLOGIST (CONT'D)
Questions. I know you got em.

JEANNE
I got forty.

CARDIOLOGIST
Then we'll take em in order.

The doctor glances once more at Ray.

CARDIOLOGIST (CONT'D)
Dad? Anything?

Ray turns the cap in his hands.

RAY
... She's got it.

INT. CARDIOLOGY OFFICE - CONFERENCE ROOM - LATER (1990)

A long table too big for the four of them.

The TRANSPLANT COORDINATOR, 40s, lays out folders.

The boy colors on the back of an intake form.

COORDINATOR
Mom flies out with him for the
workup. Two weeks, maybe three.
There's a Ronald McDonald House a
quarter mile from the hospital.
Won't cost you anything.

JEANNE
And then?

COORDINATOR
Then he's listed. And we wait for a
heart.

JEANNE
How long's the wait?

COORDINATOR

There's no answering that. Weeks.
Months. He'll wear a pager. When it
goes off you'll have four hours to
be at the hospital.

On the table between them, the pager. A little black box.

Jeanne picks it up. Turns it over. Finds the clip, the little
window, the test button. Learns it in her hands the way she
learns everything, by holding it.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)

You can test it Sunday nights. Most
folks do. Gives em something to do
with the dread.

JEANNE

Sunday nights.

COORDINATOR

It'll chirp. You'll hate the sound
of it for the rest of your life and
you'll thank God for it both.

JEANNE

Four hours.

COORDINATOR

A heart doesn't keep. It comes when
it comes. Day or night.

JEANNE

And if we miss it?

COORDINATOR

You won't miss it.

JEANNE

But if we did.

COORDINATOR

It goes to the next child on the
list.

Jeanne nods at the table. Files it where she files things.

JEANNE

So we wait on some other mother's
worst day.

A beat.

COORDINATOR

Mr. Redwine. You'll want to keep working if you can. The insurance has to stay current. That's the main thing you can do.

RAY

That's the main thing I can do.

COORDINATOR

Yes sir.

Ray at the window with his cap on. Down in the lot his truck sits small among the cars. The toolbox in the bed.

RAY

She knows the names of the parts of his heart. Ask her anything. Knows it like a mechanic.

COORDINATOR

Most families it's one of each. That's how it gets done.

Jeanne signs where the coordinator's finger lands.

Signs again. The boy hands Ray his drawing.

A horse, more or less. Too many legs or else running hard.

RAY

(to the boy)

That's a fast one.

BEAU

It's ours.

He folds it into his shirt pocket behind the cigarettes.

COORDINATOR

There's a folder here on the medications. Anti-rejection. He'll be on em the rest of his life and they're not optional, not one day, not ever.

JEANNE

The rest of his life.

COORDINATOR

However long that turns out. The drugs that save the heart are hard on the rest of him. The kidneys, mostly. That's the bargain.

Nobody loves the bargain. Everbody
signs it.

JEANNE
We'll watch the kidneys.

COORDINATOR
Twenty years out, that's the
conversation. I won't lie and say
it isn't.

Jeanne writes 'kidneys' in the notebook. Underlines it. A
thing to watch from a thousand miles off and fifteen years
early.

COORDINATOR (CONT'D)
End of the month, then.

INT. AIRPORT TERMINAL - WICHITA FALLS - DAY (1990)

Four gates. A man waxing the floor at the far end.

Jeanne walks the concourse holding the boy's hand.

Ray a pace behind with the one suitcase.

At the gate the agent is calling rows.

Jeanne kneels to the boy. Goes through his little backpack
one more time. Pills. The folder. The pager.

JEANNE
And if your ears hurt on the plane
you chew the gum. It's in the front
pocket.

BEAU
Yes ma'am.

She zips it. Holds his face a second. Stands.

The boy looks up at Ray.

Ray looks at the gate agent.

BEAU (CONT'D)
Daddy. When I come back can we get
the dirt bike?

RAY
We'll see.

BEAU
The yellow one's at Western Auto.
It's been there since--

RAY
I said we'll see.

Ray reaches down and squares the boy's collar.

RAY (CONT'D)
Mind your mama.

BEAU
Yessir.

Jeanne watches the two of them.

JEANNE
The number for the House is on the
icebox. And your girls is at my
sister's till Sunday, so--

RAY
I know where everybody's at.

A beat.

JEANNE
Alright then.

She takes the boy's hand and gets in the line.

At the door the boy turns and waves with his whole arm.

Ray lifts the hand with the gate passes in it.

Ray stands a moment. Then he's walking.

Halfway to the doors before the plane has even turned.

Then he stops. Stands in the middle of the terminal with his
back to the glass. The man waxing the floor works around him.

The engines run up outside. The pitch of it climbing.

He doesn't turn around.

EXT. KNOX CITY STREETS - (2025)

Heat standing on the blacktop.

Ray, 73, rides the bicycle down the centerline of the road.

Boarded storefronts. A bank turned church turned nothing.
He pedals slow and upright.
A scarf at his neck against the dust. Paisley silk. Knotted.
At the four-way he takes a hand off the bars to salute a
rancher's truck. The rancher lifts two fingers off the wheel.
He cuts through the Allsup's lot.
Down the alley behind the gin.
Coasting where it's smooth.
An old man's whole geography, learned to the inch.

INT. EL DORADO MOTEL - OFFICE - (2025)

The bell over the door.
Ray comes in with the heat behind him.
Takes a peppermint from the dish.

MOTEL CLERK
You're three days into the week and
I ain't seen dollars for the week.

RAY
VA check comes the third.

MOTEL CLERK
It's the ninth.

RAY
Then it's late, ain't it.
Government's late. Not me.

MOTEL CLERK
Mr. Hibbs says I can't carry nobody
past Friday. His words.

A beat.

RAY
Hibbs. I knew his daddy. His
daddy'd carry a man till Easter.

MOTEL CLERK
Well. His daddy ain't here.

Another beat.

RAY
No. None of em are.

He raps a knuckle on the counter twice.

Takes a second peppermint for the road.

The bell rings him out.

THROUGH THE GLASS:

the old man swings a leg over the bicycle.

Wobbles off true into the heat.

INT. FAMILY HOME - KITCHEN - NIGHT (1995)

Supper done. Dishes standing in the rack. Three kids at the table. Jeanne's THREE, ten to fifteen.

Not his. Everybody at the table knows it.

Homework. A radio low.

Ray, 43, comes through in a clean snap shirt, hair wet-combed, working a watch onto his wrist.

OLDEST STEPKID
You told Mama you'd stay in.

He checks his wallet against the light.

Checks his teeth in the hall glass.

OLDEST STEPKID (CONT'D)
Ray.

RAY
Lock this behind me.

The youngest, not looking up from his homework.

The door slams.

The truck cranks in the drive.

The oldest gets up and locks it.

Stands there a second with her hand on the knob.

The radio plays to the dishes.

INT. ROADHOUSE BAR - NIGHT (1995)

Low ceiling. Neon and smoke.

A pool table with a cigarette burn the size of a county on the rail.

Ray at the bar, four whiskeys deep.

He signals the BARTENDER with two fingers.

She brings the bottle and doesn't pour.

BARTENDER

D'you pay for the last two?

He lays wrinkled bills on the wood.

She pours.

BARTENDER (CONT'D)

You eat today?

RAY

Had somethin.

BARTENDER

Whiskey ain't somethin.

RAY

It's been somethin to me.

Down the bar a BIG MAN in a welder's cap holds court.

Two OTHERS with him. Laughing at something.

Ray watches them in the back-bar mirror.

The big man says something. The two others laugh on cue.

Ray's glass is empty and he doesn't signal for another.

He turns it a slow quarter turn on the wood. A quarter turn back.

A WAITRESS edges past him with a tray and he doesn't give her the room.

She goes around.

BARTENDER

Whatever you're chewin' on, swallow it or spit it out in the lot.

RAY

I ain't chewin' on nothin.

He drinks what isn't there. Sets the glass down too soft.

The jukebox turns over to something with a fiddle in it.

He carries his glass down the bar.

Leans in and says something close into the big man's ear.

We don't hear it. The jukebox has it.

The big man sets down his beer.

BIG MAN

Say it again, Mary.

Ray says it again.

It goes quick.

The big man's elbow comes back and Ray's head snaps and the bar slides him.

Glass. A stool over.

Ray comes up swinging into the second punch.

A table goes and then there's three of them on him, the big man and two others, work boots clomping.

The BARTENDER comes over the bar with a bat.

BARTENDER

Get the fuck out.

They carry Ray like he's a feed sack.

The door takes the music with it.

EXT. ROADHOUSE BAR - PARKING LOT - NIGHT (1995)

Gravel comes up at him.

He lies there among the trucks.

The door shuts. The music goes back inside.

He gets to a knee. Spits dark red.

Feels along his teeth with his tongue, taking the count.

He finds his hat by feel and sets it on.

The big man's voice from the door:

BIG MAN
Go home, Mary.

RAY
(to the gravel)
Home.

He laughs.

It costs him a rib and he quits.

He drags himself up against a dually and sits on the parking block.

Lights a cigarette with bleeding knuckles.

Moths working the sodium light.

The bartender's voice behind him.

She stands in the doorway holding his jacket.

BARTENDER
You leavin' this?

She drops it over his shoulder.

BARTENDER (CONT'D)
Go home, Ray.

The door takes her back.

Ray works his arms into the jacket one at a time.

He smokes it down to the filter before he tries his legs.

EXT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - NIGHT - (2025)

A brick ranch house. A trampoline in the yard going gray.

Ray lays the bicycle over in the grass. Takes his cap off.

Stands at the foot of the porch steps.

He knocks and steps back off the step. A salesman's distance.

A dog sets up next door. The porch light comes on.

His daughter Tammy, 45, one of the twins, behind the screen.

The door opens to the chain.

TAMMY

Daddy.

RAY

Hey.

She looks past him. His bike in the grass.

TAMMY

It's ten thirty.

RAY

Is it.

TAMMY

What about the place in Munday.

RAY

Didn't work out.

TAMMY

That's the second time.

RAY

I know it.

TAMMY

The first one in Munday I drove out
and got your stuff out of the
dumpster myself. Box of it. Your
discharge papers was in there wet.

RAY

I didn't put em in no dumpster.

TAMMY

No. The man you owed did. But it
was your name on em in the wet, not
his.

Inside, a man's voice. Her HUSBAND. Asking who it is.

She doesn't answer it.

TAMMY (CONT'D)

Darla said you called her.

RAY

I called everybody.

TAMMY

She tell you no?

RAY
She told me no.

TAMMY
Same as I'm fixin' to.

RAY
I figgered.

She doesn't shut it. Doesn't open it either.

Out at the curb his whole life leans on its kickstand. A duffel. A bedroll. A grocery sack knotted at the top.

She looks at the sack a while.

TAMMY
What's in the sack.

RAY
Few things. Don't matter.

TAMMY
It's tied like it matters.

RAY
Everthing I own's tied like it matters. That's what ownin a little does.

TAMMY
You drinkin' again?

RAY
Not tonight.

TAMMY
That ain't what I asked.

RAY
I know what you asked.

TAMMY
Then answer the one I did ask.

RAY
I had two at the Legion at noon. I rode here on a bicycle in the dark. You do the figurin on how drunk a man stays through that.

TAMMY

I quit figurin on you a long time back. It's a full-time job and it don't pay.

RAY

Your mama never quit.

TAMMY

My mama's dead, Daddy. She quit the hardest way there is. Don't you stand on my porch and hold her up to me like a thing I oughta be.

RAY

I ain't holdin her up to you.

TAMMY

You hold her up to everbody. Like bein loved by the best woman in three counties is the same as bein worth it. It ain't. She'd be the first to say it and she's the one loved you.

Cicadas.

The dog quits next door.

A truck passes the end of the street, slows at the stop sign that nobody runs out here, goes on.

The porch light has moths in it now. She watches them instead of him a second.

TAMMY (CONT'D)

Last time you stayed with me I lost a TV and Mama's coffee can. Four hundred dollars in it.

RAY

That was a long time ago.

TAMMY

It was my TV a long time ago.

RAY

I paid that back.

TAMMY

You sent Lainey a card with sixty dollars in it and called it square.

RAY
It had a horse on it.

TAMMY
She's twenty-two. She's at Tech.

RAY
Tech.

TAMMY
Engineering.

RAY
I didn't know that.

TAMMY
No. You wouldn't.

A car comes slow down the street, headlights raking the yards. Both of them watch it without seeming to. It turns in three houses down. A door, a porch light, gone.

TAMMY (CONT'D)
Darla said you was at the Allsup's
Tuesday tryin to get the boy behind
the counter to cash your check
early.

RAY
The boy knows me.

TAMMY
The boy called Darla. That's how
she knew to call me. That's how it
works now, Daddy. Y'all are a phone
tree and I'm the last number on it.

She looks at him through the gap.

The husband's shape arrives in the hall light behind her.

The door opens wider on its chain.

The HUSBAND, Bill, 50, in a Texans shirt.

BILL
Ray.

RAY
Bill.

BILL
It's ten thirty.

RAY

So I hear.

BILL

We got girls in the house, Ray.

RAY

I had girls in a house too. Once.

BILL

That supposed to mean somethin to me.

RAY

It don't have to mean nothin to you. You asked was I a danger to girls in a house. I'm tellin you I raised two in one and they're both alive and one of em's standin in this door. Make of it what you want.

BILL

Tammy.

TAMMY

I heard him, Bill.

A beat.

Tammy against the door frame.

TAMMY (CONT'D)

You got your blood pressure meds?

RAY

In the bag.

TAMMY

And the VA. You got a date?

RAY

They're workin' on a bed.

TAMMY

When.

RAY

Weeks.

TAMMY

You said weeks about Munday. That was a year and a half.

RAY
This is different.

TAMMY
It's never different.

RAY
This time there's a bed comin.
There wasn't never a bed before.

TAMMY
There's always a bed comin, Daddy.
Munday. The fella in Stamford. The
church in Haskell took you that
winter. There's been more beds
comin than I got fingers and you
wore out the welcome on ever one.

RAY
I wore out one welcome. Yours. Over
and over. It's the same one.

That lands somewhere. She looks at the boards.
He looks off down the street of brick houses.
Porch lights all the way down like buoys.

RAY (CONT'D)
I'm seventy-three years old, Tammy.

TAMMY
I know how old you are. I was there
for most of it.

She studies the porch boards.

TAMMY (CONT'D)
Mama'd tell me to shut this door.

RAY
Your mama never shut a door.

TAMMY
No.

A long moment.

RAY
It's a floor, Tammy. A few weeks.
Till the bed comes open.

Nothing.

RAY (CONT'D)
I'll keep to myself.

Behind her a small voice from the hallway.

A GRANDDAUGHTER, LEXIE, 13, in a doorway in pajamas.

LEXIE
Mama? Who is it?

Tammy holds his eyes a beat longer.

TAMMY
(to the hallway)
It's your grandpa.

She shuts the door.

The chain slides.

The door opens.

INT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - SEWING ROOM - NIGHT (2025)

A daybed under shelves of fabric and a covered machine.

Tammy pulls the good quilt down off a shelf and lays it out.

She doesn't look at him while she does it.

TAMMY
Bathroom's the girls'. Knock first.

RAY
This is fine.

TAMMY
It's a sewing room.

RAY
I slept worse.

She stops at the door.

TAMMY
Don't smoke in here.

RAY
I won't.

She goes. He stands a minute among the shelves of fabric.

Runs a thumb down a folded bolt. Then another.

RAY (CONT'D)
(to himself)
Crepe de chine.

Tammy, back in the doorway with towels. She heard it.
She sets the towels on the machine and goes and says nothing.
He sits on the daybed, takes one boot off, then the other.
He sets them under the daybed, toes to the wall, square.
He lies back on the good quilt with his clothes on. The
machine under its cover. The bolts of cloth on the shelf
above him in the dark like books in a language he can read
and won't say he can.
Down the hall the house settles, kid by kid, into its night.

INT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - LATER (2025)

Ray at the table with a reheated plate.
Brisket and beans gone soft in the microwave.
He eats like a man being graded on it.
Tammy in the doorway.
SHELBY, 16, and LEXIE, 13. Studying him like an exhibit.

SHELBY
You're our grandpa?

RAY
One of em.

LEXIE
Mama said you was dead.

RAY
She's been sayin that a while.

Shelby pulls out a chair and sits backward on it.

SHELBY
Were you in a war?

RAY
I was in the Navy.

SHELBY
Did you kill anybody?

RAY

No.

A beat.

SHELBY

How come we never met you?

Ray chases a bean around the plate.

RAY

You was little.

SHELBY

That don't count.

RAY

No. It don't.

Tammy comes through and lands two milk glasses on the table.

One for Ray too.

LEXIE

You can watch our shows tomorrow.
The baking ones.

RAY

All right.

LEXIE

A lady hollers at em when they mess
the cake up.

RAY

They pay her for that?

LEXIE

She's famous.

RAY

For hollerin?

LEXIE

Yeah.

RAY

Hm.

Lexie laughs out loud.

Shelby allows it.

Ray drinks his milk.

LEXIE
Are you stayin'?

RAY
Few days.

LEXIE
Shelby says you're gonna die in the
sewin room and we'll have to get a
new house.

SHELBY
I did not say that.

LEXIE
You said it to Brooke.

RAY
I ain't dyin in the sewin room. I
got too much pride for a sewin
room.

The little one grins. The older one doesn't, quite, but it's
close, and she takes the glasses to the sink so nobody sees
her decide about him.

LEXIE
Did you have a dog?

RAY
Had a blue heeler. Name of Pete.
Smartest thing on the place and the
meanest. Bit the propane man ever
month like a appointment.

LEXIE
What happened to him.

RAY
Got old. Same as happens.

LEXIE
That's sad.

RAY
It's the good ending, darlin. The
other ones is worse.

INT. FAMILY HOME - DINING ROOM - NIGHT (2000)

Six kids around a table built for less.

Her three, sixteen to twenty now. His TWIN DAUGHTERS, 15.
BEAU, 16, a scar up his sternum visible at the collar.

Jeanne brings the last dish and sits.

Loud the way a full table is loud. Elbows and claims and
somebody kicking somebody.

Ray at the head, 48. Drinking from a glass that isn't tea.

BEAU

Coach says I can manage the team.
Keep the stats and all.

RAY

Manage it.

BEAU

Yessir. Travel with em and
everything.

RAY

Water boy.

The boy's eyes drop to his plate. The table loses a few
degrees.

JEANNE

It's the team, Ray. He'd be on the
bus with the team.

RAY

I heard him.

He pours again. The bottle neck rings on the glass.

JEANNE

Leave it 'til after supper.

RAY

It's my house.

JEANNE

Nobody said whose house it was.

The table goes quiet by degrees. Oldest first.

One of the twins reaches and takes her brother's hand under
the table.

RAY

Nursin other men's sons.

JEANNE

Ray.

RAY

I drove that boy to Loma Linda
California and back so he could
carry a jockstrap.

JEANNE

I flew with him. You sent checks.

It gets very quiet.

RAY

Say that again.

JEANNE

Supper's gettin cold.

RAY

Say it again.

She doesn't. She passes the rolls to the nearest kid and the
kid takes one with all the care of a man defusing something.

Ray stands. His chair barks back on the boards.

Jeanne doesn't flinch.

That's its own testimony. A woman who has quit flinching.

RAY (CONT'D)

(to Jeanne)

Kitchen.

He goes. A door swings.

She sets down the serving spoon. Squares it to the dish.

JEANNE

(to the kids)

Eat.

She follows him.

INT. FAMILY HOME - DINING ROOM - CONTINUOUS (2000)

The kids at the table, every one looking at their plates.

From the kitchen his voice low and going lower. Then not low.

Something against a cabinet. A pan lid rings on tile and
circles down dead.

The twins hold hands under the table.

The son stares at the swung-shut door like he means to memorize it.

The oldest stepkid, twenty, sets his fork down and starts to rise.

The middle one pulls him back down by the wrist.

Nobody eats.

The clock over the buffet does its work.

One of the stepkids gets up quiet and starts clearing plates that aren't finished, just to have hands doing something. The scrape of the chairs. The water running.

The twins don't move. They have a stillness they've practiced, the two of them, a way of not being in a room while sitting in it.

From the kitchen it goes quiet. Quiet is worse and they all know it. The water shuts off. Somebody waits.

Then the door, and Jeanne comes back out, and her face is arranged into nothing at all, and she picks up the serving spoon and asks who wants the last of the beans like it's any supper in any year.

INT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - DAY (2025)

Saturday light through the blinds. Ray in the recliner with the paper he isn't reading.

The GRANDDAUGHTERS come through dressed to go out. Shorts. A crop top on the older.

RAY

Y'all leavin the house like that?

SHELBY

Like what.

RAY

Like that.

SHELBY

Grandpa. It's a hunderd and two out.

RAY

It was a hunderd and two in my day
too. Folks wore clothes.

LEXIE

Did they have ice?

The older one snorts.

RAY

We had ice. A man brung it in a
truck.

SHELBY

You're like off a show, Grandpa.

He shakes the paper straight. Reads nothing.

RAY

Where y'all goin anyhow?

SHELBY

Brooke's. Maybe the lake after.

RAY

What lake. There ain't no lake.

SHELBY

Miller's Creek.

RAY

That's a stock tank with a dock on
it.

LEXIE

It's got a rope swing.

RAY

It's got moccasins.

The little one comes around the recliner fighting her hair
into a braid and losing.

LEXIE

Aunt Darla does it in like two
seconds and I can't get it to stay.

Ray sets the paper down.

RAY

Come here then.

She backs up to the recliner. He sections her hair off in three with his thumb, quick, and lays the braid in fast and clean and ties it off with the band off her wrist.

Tight and straight as rope work.

LEXIE

Whoa.

SHELBY

(watching now)

Where'd you learn that at?

A beat.

RAY

Navy.

The older one looks at him a second longer than the answer's worth.

RAY (CONT'D)

Go on then. Watch for snakes.

They go. The screen door claps.

Ray picks the paper back up. His hands still remember it. You can see him notice they do.

He sits with it a while. Saturday cartoons mutter from a TV in another room.

Bill comes through in his church-league softball shirt, keys in his hand, and stops when he sees Ray in the recliner like a piece of furniture that arrived without a receipt.

BILL

Tammy run to the store.

RAY

She said.

BILL

You need anything.

RAY

I'm set.

A silence with nothing friendly in it and nothing mean either. Two men who'll never be easy and have both done the arithmetic on why.

BILL

Game's on at one if you watch ball.

RAY
I'll find it.

Bill goes. The screen door. The truck. Ray alone in the house of a man who tolerates him for a woman they both answer to.

He sits a while with the paper he isn't reading.

Somewhere in the house a dryer buzzes and nobody comes for it.

He folds the paper once, careful at the crease, and sets it on the arm of the chair square to the edge.

Old hands. They line everything up whether he tells them to or not.

EXT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - BACK FENCE - DAY (2025)

Behind the shed where the yard gives up. Dead grass and a burn barrel.

Shelby and Lexie pass something small and smoking between them.

Ray comes around the corner of the shed with a garden hose looped on his arm.

They freeze like deer.

He looks at them. Looks at it.

Holds out two fingers.

The older one hands it over.

He takes a long pull and studies the fence line. Lets it go slow.

RAY
This is better'n what we had.

SHELBY
It's Colorado's.

RAY
Hm.

He hands it back.

SHELBY
You're not gonna tell Mama.

RAY
Tell her what.

The little one starts laughing and can't quit.

LEXIE
(through it)
He took it like a -- you didn't
even look around first.

RAY
Lookin around's how you get caught.

He sets the hose down. Settles against the shed wall in the
shade with them.

SHELBY
Did you smoke when you were our
age?

RAY
When I was your age I was buckin
hay for a dollar a day. Smoked
whatever the man drivin the truck
smoked.

LEXIE
What'd he smoke?

RAY
Pall Malls. Like a chimney fire.

SHELBY
Mama says you used to grow it. Out
behind Granny's.

RAY
Your mama talks a lot for somebody
never got caught at nothin.

SHELBY
So it's true.

RAY
It was tomatoes mostly.

LEXIE
Mostly.

RAY
Tomatoes need a tall fence.

The older one laughs now too. The sound carries off over the
dead yard.

A mockingbird runs through everything it knows on the wire.

LEXIE
Was Granny pretty?

The smoke hangs a second.

RAY
She was sellin flowers when I met
her. Out of a basket. Prettiest
thing in Tarrant County and she's
hawkin two-dollar roses to drunks.

SHELBY
Did you buy one?

RAY
Bought the whole basket. Over the
course of a evenin.

LEXIE
That's so romantic.

RAY
It was a financial decision.

LEXIE
You're not like Mama said.

RAY
Yeah I am, darlin.

He says it easy. Like the weather.

He picks up the hose and goes on toward the spigot.

The girls look at each other.

LEXIE
(calling after him)
You want a Coke? We got Cokes in
the shed fridge.

RAY
(not turning)
I want a Coke.

She runs one out to him. He cracks it on the edge of the
spigot housing the old way, no opener, and hands the cap to
her like it's something.

LEXIE
What do I do with it.

RAY
Keep it. You'll be old someday and
you'll want to know a man could
open a Coke on anything.

She pockets the cap. She will, in fact, keep it. The film
knows this. She doesn't yet.

SHELBY
Mama says you weren't ever around.
For her. Growin up.

RAY
That's true.

SHELBY
You don't even fight it.

RAY
What's to fight. I was where I was.
Wasn't here. That's the whole of it
and there ain't a better way to say
it that makes it not so.

Shelby studies him. It's not the answer she came loaded for
and it disarms her more than an excuse would have.

EXT. FAMILY HOME - BACK PASTURE - DAY (2000)

A dead tractor sinking into the dirt it quit on.

The TWINS, 15, up on the wheel hubs. BEAU, 16, on the hitch,
passing a joint.

He takes small careful drags. A hand flat over the scar on
his chest like he's holding something in.

Ray comes through the gate.

They don't bother hiding it. Past that, the lot of them.

TWIN (TAMMY)
Mama's lookin for you.

RAY
That's all right.

He climbs up on the fender. The son passes it to him without
being asked.

They smoke. Mesquite and a far-off train.

BEAU
You ever gonna fix this tractor?

RAY
Nope.

TWIN (DARLA)
Why not?

RAY
Quit on me in front of God and
everybody. It can set there and
think about it.

The son laughs. It turns into a cough and the twins both look
at him at once, the same head-turn, the same eyes.

He waves them off.

BEAU
I'm good.

TWIN (TAMMY)
Donnie Pruett's daddy fixed his.

RAY
Donnie Pruett's daddy's got money
to throw at a dead tractor. I got
y'all.

TWIN (DARLA)
That supposed to be sweet?

RAY
Take it how it lands.

The son flicks ash careful into the dirt. Heels it under.

BEAU
Mama find out we're out here, it
ain't the smokin she'll be mad
about. It's that you're nice out
here and not in there.

Ray takes a long pull on that one.

Nobody says anything for a while. The train gets where it was
going.

It's almost peace. The nearest this family gets to it.

INT. FAMILY HOME - NIGHT (2000)

Boxes by the door. Taped and labeled in a woman's hand.

Jeanne's three kids ferry them out to a truck idling in the drive with its lights off.

JEANNE, 46, wraps glasses at the counter in newspaper. She doesn't hurry.

Ray stands in the kitchen doorway with a beer he isn't drinking.

RAY
Where you gonna go.

JEANNE
My sister's.

RAY
That's three hours.

JEANNE
I know how far it is.

She wraps another glass. Sets it in the box like an egg.

RAY
Who's gonna -- the boy's
appointments. Thursdays.

JEANNE
I'll be back Thursdays.

RAY
Three hours both ways ever
Thursday.

JEANNE
I been drivin further for less.

The OLDEST STEPKID, 20 now, comes through and takes the box out of her hands.

Gives Ray a look on his way out that Ray doesn't answer.

RAY
And the twins? The boy?

JEANNE
They're yours.

She says it like a sentence handed down. Like it costs her exactly what it costs.

RAY
You're leavin your own kids.

JEANNE
I'm leavin YOU. Don't you dare
stand there and make it somethin
else.

The first raised voice of the night and it's done as quick as
it came.

She goes back to the glasses. Wraps the last one.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
Them three in the truck ain't slept
right in this house in years. The
twins and the boy -- this is the
only roof they got and you're under
it. That's the arithmetic. I done
it ever way it goes.

RAY
I never laid a hand on them kids.
Not once.

JEANNE
No. You made em watch instead.

Ray looks at the beer in his hand like he's just now seeing
it.

She takes up the last box. Stops in front of him a moment.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
You was sweet once. I'd've swore to
it on a Bible.

RAY
Jeanne--

JEANNE
Don't.

She looks at him a long moment. Whatever she's looking for,
it was there once. She quit finding it a while back and looks
anyway out of habit.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
There's a casserole in the freezer
says TUESDAY on it. That's for
Tuesday.

RAY
Jeanne.

JEANNE

And the boy's pills is sorted in
the days-of-the-week thing. Don't
let him sort em hisself, he stacks
Thursdays.

Her voice doesn't break. It's past breaking. It's
housekeeping.

The screen door claps.

The truck backs out dark and is gone down the road.

Ray stands in the kitchen with the icebox hum.

Down the hall a door eases shut. One of the twins, listening
the whole time.

He stands a long while. Then he goes to the freezer and finds
the casserole that says TUESDAY and reads the word in her
hand and puts it back and shuts the door.

He sits at the table where the suppers used to be loud.

The icebox hums. A truck three hours gone.

INT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT (2025)

A bottle on the counter. Half gone. It was full this morning.

Tammy holds it up. Bill behind her with his arms crossed.

TAMMY

It was in the girls' bathroom. In
the tank of the toilet.

RAY

It ain't mine.

TAMMY

Daddy.

RAY

You raisin liars then. I don't know
what to tell you.

Bill shifts his weight. Ray puts his eyes on him.

RAY (CONT'D)

You got somethin?

BILL

Not a thing.

TAMMY

You swore to me. On Mama.

RAY

Don't bring her into your kitchen.

TAMMY

She's the only thing ever made you
act human and she's been dead
fifteen years. I'll bring her where
I want.

Quiet. The icemaker dumps.

Ray picks up the bottle. Slow. Like evidence in a trial
already lost.

He pours it out in the sink with great ceremony.

RAY

There.

TAMMY

That ain't what this is and you
know it.

He sets the empty in the sink gentle as church glass.

RAY

I'll be out Friday.

TAMMY

Daddy--

RAY

Friday.

He goes down the hall. The sewing room door shuts.

Tammy stands there holding nothing.

She looks at the empty bottle in the sink. The neat way he
set it down. Even drunk, even caught, the man squares things
to the edge.

She runs the water and rinses it and sets it in the recycling
and stands with her hands on the counter a while.

Down the hall, no sound from the sewing room. Which is its
own kind of sound.

INT. DIALYSIS CENTER - WICHITA FALLS - DAY (2005)

Rows of recliners and machines that murmur like livestock.

BEAU, 21 now, tethered at the arm. A cap on backwards.
Thinner than a man his age ought to be.

JEANNE, 51, beside him, knitting without looking at her hands.

Ray, 53, comes down the row carrying two vending machine coffees.

He stops a chair short. Sits a chair short. Nobody to give the second coffee to.

BEAU
Daddy. They got a TV.

RAY
I see it.

BEAU
You don't gotta stay the whole four hours.

RAY
I know I don't.

He stays.

On the TV a man is winning a boat. The whole row of tethered people watches him win it.

A NURSE moves down the row checking pressures, writing on a clipboard chained to her cart. She knows every name in the chairs and says each one going by. Pearl. Dwight. Bo.

She gets to Beau, reads his line, taps the machine twice, moves on without a word because there's no word due.

BEAU
What would you even do with a boat.

RAY
Around here? Pay to park it.

BEAU
Donnie's got a bass boat on a lake lot at Possum Kingdom.

RAY
Donnie's daddy owns half of Seymour.

BEAU

You was in the Navy and we never even had a canoe. That's a federal crime probly.

RAY

Navy cured me of water.

The boy grins under the cap. The machine draws and returns. Draws and returns.

In the next chair an OLD RANCHER, 70s, tethered the same, hat on his knee.

OLD RANCHER

Your boy's got a sense of humor. That's worth more'n the machine.

RAY

Gets it from his mama.

OLD RANCHER

I been comin here four years. You get to where you know everbody's blood better'n their name.

RAY

That right.

OLD RANCHER

That fella yonder's a Tuesday-Thursday like us. Schoolteacher. The lady by the window's a Monday-Wednesday-Friday. Monday-Wednesday-Fridays is worse off, generally.

Ray looks down the row at the lady by the window. She waves. He lifts the coffee an inch.

OLD RANCHER (CONT'D)

You don't talk much.

RAY

Not much to add.

OLD RANCHER

Well. You're settin in the right buildin for that.

The rancher's machine chimes some small private alarm. A nurse comes, thumbs a button, goes.

OLD RANCHER (CONT'D)

Four years I been watchin that boy
of yours run his mouth at this
room. Does it good. Does all of em
good.

RAY

He don't get it from me.

OLD RANCHER

No. Quiet ones we got plenty of.

He settles his hat lower and shuts his eyes, done talking,
the way men out here close a gate.

A TECH, 30s, comes down the line checking lines and numbers.

TECH

How we feelin, Beau?

BEAU

Like a million bucks somebody's
holdin for me.

TECH

That's the spirit.

The tech adjusts something. Writes something. Goes on.

Ray watches the lines. The dark draw and the bright return.

RAY

(low, to Jeanne)
They say anything?

JEANNE

Same as Tuesday.

RAY

Which was.

JEANNE

That they'd say somethin when
there's somethin to say.

Click and click. She turns the work in her lap.

RAY

And the list? For the kidney?

JEANNE

He's on it.

RAY

He was on the other list too. That one moved.

JEANNE

He was six and dyin. They move quicker for the six-year-olds.

Ray sets the second coffee on the little table by the boy's chair. The boy's eyes are closed now.

The cap has slid sideways. Ray squares it without waking him. The same two-finger touch as the collar at the airport, 1990.

RAY

He oughta be fishin. Twenty-one years old.

JEANNE

He oughta be a lot of things.

She counts stitches with her lips moving.

JEANNE (CONT'D)

He quit the community college. Did he tell you?

RAY

No.

JEANNE

Tuesdays and Thursdays got to be machine days. Can't be two things on a Tuesday.

Ray looks down the row. Eight chairs. Eight machines. The murmur of all of it.

RAY

This is the heart all over again. Just slower.

JEANNE

Heart they give him was never gonna carry him to old. You knew that. You just quit listenin after the part where he lives.

RAY

Then they oughta said it plainer.

JEANNE

They said it plain as rain, Ray. You was in the truck.

RAY
I was workin.

JEANNE
You was workin. That's the
headstone for the both of us. He
was sick and you was workin and I
was learnin the parts of his heart
and that's the whole marriage in
three rooms.

RAY
Somebody had to keep the lights on.

JEANNE
The lights stayed on. I'll give you
the lights. It's the rest of the
house was dark.

That sits between them. The machine draws and returns.

On the TV they spin the wheel. Applause from somewhere with
better weather.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
You smell like the Legion hall.

RAY
I had one. With lunch.

JEANNE
Mm.

She doesn't look up from the knitting. Twenty-five years of
that 'mm.'

The boy stirs. Eyes still shut.

BEAU
Y'all know I ain't asleep.

JEANNE
Nobody said you was, baby.

BEAU
Three more months of Tuesdays and I
get moved up the list. Tech said.

Neither of them answers right away. Jeanne's needles keep on.

RAY
Then we'll get the boat.

The boy smiles without opening his eyes.

BEAU
Now you're talkin.

EXT. DIALYSIS CENTER - PARKING LOT - DAY (2005)

Ray smokes by the truck with one boot up on the bumper.

Through the window glass: the row of recliners. His boy small in the big chair. His wife's needles going.

He smokes it shorter than he wants to.

Drops it. Heels it. Goes back in.

INT. DIALYSIS CENTER - CONTINUOUS (2005)

He sits back down a chair short.

BEAU
(eyes shut)
Them things'll kill you, Daddy.

RAY
Somethin's got to.

BEAU
Get in line, tell it.

The old rancher laughs at that. Jeanne doesn't.

Ray drinks the cold coffee. Stays the whole four hours.

INT. DIALYSIS CENTER - LATER (2005)

The light gone long through the blinds. The row half empty now.

The boy sleeps for real. Jeanne has the knitting put away and her coat on her lap.

Ray watches the blood go out of his son dark and come back changed.

RAY
(quiet)
Where's it all go. What it takes out of him.

JEANNE
Filter. Same as a oil change.

RAY
I know how it works. That ain't
what I mean.

She looks at him then. First time all day.

JEANNE
I know what you mean.

The machine winds down its cycle. A nurse begins the
unhooking, gentle, practiced.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
You don't come Tuesdays for him,
you know. He'd let you off. He lets
everybody off everthing.

RAY
Then who'm I comin for.

JEANNE
Whoever it is, he drinks his coffee
cold and stays the whole four
hours.

She stands and gathers her coat.

The boy comes awake easy, like surfacing. Looks for them
first thing. Finds them both there.

BEAU
Whataburger?

RAY
Whataburger.

The nurse coils the lines. The machine goes quiet and the
quiet of it is loud.

The boy stands too fast and steadies on the chair arm and
pretends he didn't.

Ray pretends he didn't see it. Jeanne takes the boy's arm
like it's hers that's tired.

The three of them go down the row past the lady by the
window.

BEAU
(to her)
See you Thursday, Miss Pearl.

Out the glass doors into the long light. The truck waiting in
the heat like a patient animal.

INT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT (2025)

Late. The TV doing an infomercial to an empty couch.

The freezer door stands open. Frost smoking off it.

A bottle of vodka down from the top shelf, standing on the counter, opened.

The good quilt from the sewing room is balled on the kitchen floor.

A kitchen chair lies on its side. Nobody in the room.

Down the hall a thump. Then another. A glass somewhere.

Tammy's bedroom door opens. Hall light on.

INT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS (2025)

Ray naked in the hallway, propped against the thermostat.

Naked but for a thin gold chain at his throat. A woman's chain.

He is talking to the hall. To people in it and people not.

RAY

--because it's MY name on it. My name. You ask Jeanne. JEANNE.

TAMMY

Daddy.

RAY

Tell your mama to come look at this.

TAMMY

Daddy. It's Tammy. You're at my house.

He focuses on her and doesn't arrive.

RAY

Tammy's fifteen.

Bill in the bedroom doorway with his phone already at his ear, turned away, voice low.

Down the hall the girls' door cracks. The little one's face in the gap.

TAMMY
(not turning)
Shut the door, Lexie.

The door doesn't shut.

RAY
Where's my -- somebody's took my
clothes. Somebody in this house.

TAMMY
Your clothes are in the sewing
room, Daddy. Right where you took
em off.

RAY
That ain't my room. My room's at
the motel.

TAMMY
Okay.

RAY
Room 7. It's wrote on the key.

TAMMY
You don't live at a motel, Daddy.
You live in my sewing room. As of
Tuesday. You signed nothin and you
paid nothin and that's the deal and
you been here three weeks.

RAY
Three weeks.

TAMMY
Three weeks tomorrow.

He looks at her like the number is a country he's never been
to.

TAMMY (CONT'D)
Okay, Daddy.

He slides down the wall a foot. Catches himself on the
thermostat. The cover snaps off it and skitters.

Shelby is in the hall now with a quilt held out at arm's
length, not looking at him.

Tammy takes it. Wraps it around his shoulders. He fights it
like a man fighting a net.

RAY
GET OFF -- get off me--

TAMMY
Nobody's on you. It's a quilt.

And then the fight goes out of him all at once, the way it does, and he's an old man on the floor of a hallway holding a quilt shut at his own throat.

Red and blue light through the front windows. Sweeping the family photos up the wall and down.

INT./EXT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - FRONT DOOR - LATER (2025)

Two DEPUTIES, young, hats off in the house. Two PARAMEDICS with a gurney on the porch.

Everyone working him calm the way men gentle a colt.

PARAMEDIC
Ray? Ray. We're just gonna take a ride. Get your numbers looked at.

RAY
I know you?

PARAMEDIC
No sir. Not yet. I'm Danny.

RAY
Danny.

PARAMEDIC
Yessir.

RAY
(settling some)
I knew a Danny on the Wrightson.
Knocked his front teeth out on a hatch ring.

PARAMEDIC
Well I'll watch my step.

They walk him to the living room. Sit him on the couch in the quilt.

The second PARAMEDIC velcros a cuff on him. Pumps it. Watches the dial.

PARAMEDIC #2
One-eighty-five over a hundred.
When'd you eat last, Mr. Redwine?

RAY
I eat fine.

TAMMY
He didn't touch supper.

RAY
Supper had squash in it.

The paramedic clips a monitor on his finger. Ray studies it like a wasp landed on him.

The cuff comes off. The paramedic's eyes pass over the gold chain. Stop a half second.

PARAMEDIC
We'll take the necklace off at the hospital, sir. They'll bag it for you. It's safe.

RAY
It stays on.

PARAMEDIC
It's just policy if they image you--

RAY
It stays on.

Something in how he says it. The paramedic looks at Tammy. Tammy gives the smallest shake of her head: let it go.

PARAMEDIC
Okay. It stays on.

They get him to the gurney. He sits on it like a man who's decided sitting was his idea.

The DEPUTY at the door, quiet, to Tammy:

DEPUTY
Ma'am, we ain't writin nothin up.
But the next one of these is a 5150
hold whether anybody wants it or
not. Y'all might get ahead of it.

TAMMY
We been tryin to get ahead of it
since I was in grade school.

The deputy nods at his hat.

They wheel Ray out under the sweeping light. The quilt up to his chin. The gold chain above it, catching red, then blue, then red.

Across the street a porch light comes on. Then another two doors down.

Knox City taking attendance.

A WOMAN in a robe across the street stands on her porch with her arms crossed. She and Tammy lift a hand to each other. Nothing to say. Everybody on this street has had a night with lights in it.

Two houses down a man in boxers and boots watches from his garage, a beer already going, like it's a show that comes on now and then.

Tammy stands in the yard in her robe with her arms crossed, watching them load him.

Bill beside her in gym shorts, hands on his hips, studying the grass.

BILL

Tam.

TAMMY

Don't say it tonight, Bill. Say it tomorrow if you got to say it.

He doesn't say it.

The ambulance pulls out without the siren. The deputies idle a minute and follow.

The porch lights across the street go off one at a time, satisfied.

INT. TAMMY'S HOUSE - KITCHEN - LATER (2025)

Tammy rights the chair.

Closes the freezer.

Pours the vodka down the sink standing the way her daddy stood pouring his, and catches herself doing it and sets the bottle down hard.

Shelby in the doorway.

SHELBY
Is he gonna die?

TAMMY
Not tonight.

SHELBY
That's not what I asked.

Tammy looks at her. Sixteen and already asking the family question the family way.

TAMMY
Go to bed, baby.

From the girls' room, the little one at the window, watching the red lights get small between the houses.

EXT. FAMILY HOME - DAY (2010)

The truck rolls up the drive. Ray, 58, gathers grocery sacks off the bench seat, takes the mail from the box.

Flips through it walking. Bill. Bill. A flyer for a gospel sing in Munday.

The boy's hatchback in its spot by the propane tank. Game music coming faint through the screen door, looping its little song.

INT. FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS (2010)

He shoulders through the door talking before he's in.

RAY
They had brisket on special so I
don't want to hear nothin about--

BEAU in the recliner. 26. A video game paused on the TV. His head over on his shoulder like a man dozing through the fourth quarter.

Ray stops where he is.

The mail comes out from under his arm a piece at a time and cards the floor.

RAY (CONT'D)
Hey now.

The boy doesn't move. The game's little song loops.

RAY (CONT'D)

Hey now.

He doesn't go to him. Not yet. As long as he stands here holding groceries it can still be sleep.

The window unit cycles. Out on the road a truck goes by and is gone.

Ray sets the sacks down slow. Crosses the room like the floor might give.

Puts two fingers to the boy's neck. The same two fingers. Collar. Cap. This.

He stands there a long time with his fingers on his son's neck, looking at the screen like it owes him an answer.

On it the game waits. A little figure standing in a field, breathing the way they do. Waiting on a hand.

His hand moves from the neck to the boy's shoulder. Stays.

The window unit cycles off. The house goes all the way quiet.

RAY (CONT'D)

(barely)

All right.

He doesn't reach for the phone yet. He stands in his own living room like a stranger to it, his hand on his boy, the ice cream going soft in the sack by the door.

INT. FAMILY HOME - DAY - LATER (2010)

The room full of strangers and equipment.

Two PARAMEDICS, an ENGINE CREW that wasn't needed and won't leave, a SHERIFF'S DEPUTY filling out the worst form there is.

A NEIGHBOR has come over and is standing in the yard not knowing whether to come in. He holds his cap. He has known Beau since the boy was on a tricycle and he cannot make himself cross the porch.

Inside, the television Beau left on is still going, a game show, the host delighted about something, and nobody can find the will or the remote to shut it off.

A FIREMAN folds the recliner footrest down with a tenderness out of all keeping with his size.

Two more in turnout coats stand in the kitchen with their helmets off, not knowing where to put their hands.

One of them has found the dish towel and is drying a glass that was already dry. Just to be doing.

A radio on a hip mutters numbers and a woman's voice answers it from miles off.

The screen door stands propped with a brick and the heat comes in and nobody shuts it.

Ray in the kitchen doorway. Somebody has put the boy's cap in his hands and he cannot now find anyone to hand it back to.

DEPUTY (2010)
Sir? Date of birth on your son?

RAY
March. March the uh.

He turns the cap in his hands.

RAY (CONT'D)
Eighty-four. March the ninth,
eighty-four.

DEPUTY (2010)
Full name?

RAY
Ray.

The deputy looks up.

RAY (CONT'D)
He's Ray too. Beau's the middle.
Wasn't nobody ever called him Ray.

The deputy writes it. Junior and all.

DEPUTY (2010)
And he was -- he had a heart
condition? On file?

RAY
He had a transplant when he was
six. Loma Linda California.

DEPUTY (2010)
Okay.

RAY
They said it'd carry him twenty
years if it carried him ten.

The deputy writes.

RAY (CONT'D)
It carried him twenty.

The deputy stops writing.

DEPUTY (2010)
I'm awful sorry, Mr. Redwine.

A sedan noses up the drive behind the ambulance. A big man in a sport shirt gets out with a clipboard. The JUSTICE OF THE PEACE.

In Knox County the JP pronounces. He's done it for cattle prices and car wrecks and old women in their beds and it has not gotten easier and he has quit expecting it to.

JUSTICE OF THE PEACE
(at the door, hat off)
Ray.

RAY
Pete.

JUSTICE OF THE PEACE
I got to go look at him a minute.
That all right.

RAY
He's by the TV.

The JP goes in. The men in the room make a lane for him without being asked.

Out the front window JEANNE arrives at a run from somewhere, NEIGHBOR WOMEN flanking her before she's off the porch steps.

The sound she makes gets into the house anyway.

Ray doesn't go to her. He watches through the glass like weather.

She comes in past everybody. Past the JP. Goes down on her knees at the recliner and takes the boy's hand like she's checking his homework.

The room looks away as one man.

JEANNE
(to the boy, low)
Okay. Okay, baby. Mama's here.

Ray stands apart with the cap, in his own living room, third from his own grief in line behind his wife and the county.

EXT. FAMILY HOME - DRIVEWAY - LATER (2010)

The gurney comes out made up and buckled. Sheet to the chin, like they're keeping him warm.

The neighbor women have Jeanne on the porch step, one on each side, holding her down to the earth.

Ray follows the gurney with the cap.

At the ambulance doors a PARAMEDIC bars his way with a kind arm.

PARAMEDIC (2010)
You can follow us in, sir. It's
just the county road.

RAY
I'll ride with him.

PARAMEDIC (2010)
Sir, there ain't a -- it's not a
transport where--

RAY
I'll ride with him.

The paramedic looks at him. At the cap in his hands.

Steps aside.

INT. AMBULANCE - MOVING - DAY (2010)

No siren. No hurry to it now. The county road unspooling slow out the back glass.

Ray on the bench beside the gurney. The strap creaks where he holds it.

The PARAMEDIC rides across from him, hands folded, looking at the floor out of respect or out of practice.

RAY
He had a appointment Thursday.

PARAMEDIC (2010)

Yessir.

RAY

Machine days was Tuesday Thursday.
He never missed one. Five years and
he never missed a one.

PARAMEDIC (2010)

That's somethin.

RAY

His mama had a casserole goin for
after.

The paramedic nods at the floor.

Ray looks at the shape under the sheet. The boots somebody
set together square on the lower rack.

RAY (CONT'D)

I was gettin brisket. They had it
on special.

PARAMEDIC (2010)

Yessir.

RAY

Man's son dies in a recliner while
he's pickin out brisket.

PARAMEDIC (2010)

You couldn't of knowed.

RAY

That ain't the part.

PARAMEDIC (2010)

What's the part.

RAY

That I'd of bought the brisket
anyhow. Knowin or not. That's the
part.

The paramedic doesn't answer. There's no answer and he's
young enough to know better than to invent one.

The ambulance slows. Turns. Gravel under the tires now.

Ray puts the cap on the sheet, over where the boy's heart
would be. Squares it. Two fingers.

RAY (CONT'D)
(to the sheet)
All right then.

Out the back window the caliche dust hangs over the road behind them like the land closing up after.

INT. COUNTY HOSPITAL - SERVICE CORRIDOR - DAY (2010)

A back hallway. Buffed floor and fluorescent hum.

They wheel the gurney through doors marked AUTHORIZED and Ray walks beside it with his hand on the rail of it like a pallbearer at half strength.

At a second set of doors an ORDERLY stops, gentle.

ORDERLY
Sir, this is far as family goes.

Ray doesn't let go of the rail right away.

Then he does.

They take the boy through. The doors flap twice and settle.

INT. COUNTY HOSPITAL - WAITING AREA - DAY (2010)

Ray in a plastic chair with the cap.

A CLERK with a clipboard, apologetic at a distance, working up to him.

HOSPITAL CLERK
Mr. Redwine? Whenever you're able.
No hurry at all. It's just the one
signature.

He signs where her finger lands. The same way his wife signed Loma Linda. Twenty years between the two signatures and both of them for the same heart.

HOSPITAL CLERK (CONT'D)
Can I call somebody for you?

RAY
No ma'am. They'll be along.

She goes. He sits with the cap.

Down the hall a baby is crying somewhere in the world.

He turns the cap over. Inside the band, in ballpoint, in a kid's hand from some year: B. REDWINE.

He puts it crown-down on his knee, the way you'd set a hat at a funeral, and waits for whoever's coming.

INT. COUNTY HOSPITAL - ER BAY - NIGHT (2025)

Curtain track and monitor light.

Ray in a gown, tubed and taped. The business of saving a man who didn't ask.

A NURSE, 50s, hangs a bag and talks over him in numbers to somebody in the hall.

The gold chain still at his throat. Somebody has taped over it rather than fight him.

His eyes half open on the ceiling tile.

The tile has a water stain shaped like nothing. He works at it anyway.

NURSE

Mr. Redwine. You know where you're at?

RAY

Hospital.

NURSE

Which one?

RAY

The one with the questions.

NURSE

You know what year it is?

RAY

One I'd as soon give back.

NURSE

That ain't a year, hon.

RAY

It's the truest answer you'll get tonight.

NURSE

That's all of em, sugar.

She checks the line in his arm. He watches the dark draw of his own blood into a vial.

RAY

My boy done this five years. Twice a week.

NURSE

Done what, hon?

RAY

Blood goin out and comin back.

She caps the vial. Pats his arm.

NURSE

Try and rest.

A young ER DOCTOR sweeps the curtain back. Reads the chart like a man reading a menu he knows by heart.

ER DOCTOR

Mr. Redwine. Your blood alcohol came back at point-three-one. You know what that number means?

RAY

Means I walked in here. Most men it'd mean a hearse.

ER DOCTOR

It means your body's had a lot of practice. That's not the compliment you think it is.

RAY

Didn't take it as one.

The doctor looks at him a moment over the chart.

ER DOCTOR

We pumped your stomach. We're running fluids. Your liver numbers I'll talk to you about in the morning when you'll remember it.

RAY

I'll remember it now.

ER DOCTOR

No sir. You won't.

He clips the chart to the rail and goes, curtain swaying.

The monitor settles into its slow count.

The fluorescents hum down to something else. The room going long and soft at its edges.

INT. ER BAY - HIS DELIRIUM - NIGHT (2025)

The curtain stands open onto a dark that isn't the hallway.

BEAU is sitting at the foot of the bed. Backwards cap. Twenty-six forever.

He watches the monitor like it's the TV at dialysis.

BEAU

They got you on the machine now.

RAY

Seems like.

BEAU

It ain't so bad. You get used to the sound.

RAY

I never did.

BEAU

You wasn't the one in the chair.

The boy picks at the blanket hem. The exact way he picked at the recliner arm.

BEAU (CONT'D)

You never got the boat neither.

RAY

I know it.

BEAU

It's all right. Wouldn't of fit in the motel.

Ray laughs. It hurts somewhere taped.

And by the window, where the parking lot lights ought to be, JEANNE. Young. The age she was at Billy Bob's. A flower basket on her arm.

JEANNE

You never did call the girls.

RAY
I'm in one of the girls' towns
right now.

JEANNE
Bein in a town ain't callin.

She comes and stands at the rail. Looks him over the way she
looked over a rose before she'd put it in the basket.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
They was gonna take my chain off
you.

RAY
I didn't let em.

JEANNE
I know you didn't.

She reaches and squares the tape over the chain. He feels it
or doesn't. Same two fingers he used on collars and caps.
Hers first. He learned it somewhere.

RAY
Jeanne. The stuff in my bag. At the
motel.

JEANNE
I know what's in the bag, Ray.

Quiet. The monitor counting.

RAY
You knew the whole time.

JEANNE
Married to a man thirty year, you
know what drawer he don't open in
front of you.

RAY
You never said nothin.

JEANNE
Neither did you. That was the
marriage.

RAY
I kept the worst of it off you.
That was the most I knew to do for
a person.

JEANNE

I know it was. That's the saddest thing about you, Ray. The keepin-off was you tryin to be kind.

RAY

It wasn't enough.

JEANNE

No. But I seen what it cost you. I'm the only one ever did. Don't go thinkin nobody ever seen it.

She says it without heat. A fact of the land, like rainfall.

BEAU

(at the foot of the bed)
Y'all gonna fight? This is the best TV in the buildin.

JEANNE

Hush.

She tucks the blanket edge under Ray's arm. Housekeeping. Even here.

RAY

I'da told you. If there'd been a way to say it in them days.

JEANNE

There wasn't.

RAY

No. There wasn't.

JEANNE

There is now, though.

He looks at her. The basket. The lot lights coming back through her a little.

RAY

Who'd I tell now? Everbody that mattered's in this room.

The NURSE leans in through the vision, checking the line, and the room is fluorescent again.

NURSE

Who you talkin to, baby?

He looks at the foot of the bed. Empty blanket.

The window. Parking lot lights.

RAY
Nobody. Family.

The nurse writes it on the chart without comment. She has
charted stranger answers from soberer men.

NURSE
Your daughter's in the waitin room.
Been there since they brung you in.

RAY
She don't have to be.

NURSE
No. She don't. That's generally how
you tell the real ones from the
others. The real ones don't have to
be and they're there anyhow.

Ray turns that over. Looks at the dark window where his dead
wife stood a minute ago.

RAY
Send her in then. Before the other
one comes back.

NURSE
Other one?

RAY
Never mind. You wouldn't see her
noways. She only comes for me.

The nurse pats his arm and goes for the daughter, and the
window holds nothing but the lot and the long night and the
count of the machine.

The nurse marks the chart.

INT. COUNTY HOSPITAL - ER BAY - DAWN (2025)

Gray light in the blinds. The monitor still counting.

Tammy in the chair by the bed, asleep sitting up, her purse
held on her lap like a passenger on a bus.

Ray awake. Watching her.

Watching the way her hands hold the purse. Her mother's
hands. The whole inheritance.

He doesn't wake her.

Out the window the parking lot lights go off all at once. The day coming on whether anybody asked it to or not.

EXT. CEMETERY - OUTSIDE MUNDAY - DAY (2010)

Caliche road in. Mesquite fence line. A green canopy popping in the wind like a sail.

Cars and trucks parked in the bar ditch a quarter mile down both directions.

Half the county. She fed most of it at one time or another.

The twins' car comes up the road. Ray gets out of the back seat of it, a man delivered.

He stands by the door a moment working his collar button with two fingers that have quit being good at it.

TWIN (DARLA)
Here, Daddy.

She does the button. He looks over her head at the canopy while she does it.

RAY
Big turnout.

TWIN (DARLA)
She was loved.

RAY
I know it.

The walk in. People nodding at the twins. Touching the twins' arms. Their eyes sliding past Ray like he's parked wrong.

A casket over the hole. Sprays of flowers fighting the wind.

JEANNE is the one in the box.

Eight months after her boy. Like a woman following a child through a door.

The PREACHER hurries the words against the weather.

PREACHER
...and Jeanne never met a stranger,
nor turned one away hungry...

Her three kids on one side. Grown. Families of their own arranged behind them like fence posts.

The TWINS, 25, on the other side, holding hands the way they did under the table.

And Ray. In a suit that fit him at some other funeral. Standing apart. The place where a row would have been held for him if rows were held for him.

The wind takes a flower arrangement off its easel. Two men in boots reset it without a word.

Down the front row the three step-children stand shoulder to shoulder, grown, their own children corralled at their knees. The oldest, Mike, keeps his eyes forward. The middle one keeps hers on Ray, steady, the way you keep an eye on a dog you don't trust at a gathering.

The twins hold to each other. Darla's husband stands a half step back, a hand on her shoulder, the easy weight of a man allowed to comfort his wife in public. Ray watches that hand a while. The simple permission of it.

PREACHER (CONT'D)

...She is survived by her daughters
Tammy and Darla. Her sons Mike,
Daniel, and Lonnie. Eleven
grandbabies. ...And by Ray Redwine.

And by Ray Redwine. A survivor the way a chimney survives a house fire.

Heads do not turn to him. The not-turning is loud.

The preacher closes the book against the wind.

PREACHER (CONT'D)

Y'all join me. The Lord is my
shepherd, I shall not want...

The crowd takes it up. Forty voices leaning on the old words.

Ray's mouth moves with it. No sound. He knows it the way you know a road you don't drive anymore.

A WOMAN starts a hymn high and alone -- 'In the Sweet By and By' -- and the crowd comes under it voice by voice and carries it.

The wind drops out of respect or coincidence.

Ray stands in the singing like a fence post in a river.

He does not sing loud enough for the woman beside him to hear, and she is a stranger, and she leans away from him a half inch all the same.

The hymn finds its last verse. Somewhere a baby fusses and is carried off toward the cars.

The preacher lifts a hand and the wind takes the gesture and makes it bigger than the man.

Across the casket one of her grandbabies, four years old, waves at him. The only one out here who doesn't know better.

Ray lifts two fingers off his hat brim. The child's mother turns the child gently forward by the shoulder.

The casket goes down on the straps, the men paying out the webbing hand over hand, gentle as lowering a boat.

The twins each drop a rose. Her three kids each drop a handful of dirt.

It comes around to Ray last. The funeral man offers the little brass cup of dirt.

Ray looks at it.

Takes a rose instead from the spray. Drops it down onto the lid among the dirt.

Nobody says anything about it. Everybody sees it.

EXT. CEMETERY - AFTER THE AMEN - DAY (2010)

The crowd breaks into its clumps. Hugs and hats held on against the wind.

Casseroles already being staged in truck beds like a supply line.

The OLDEST STEPKID, Mike, 30 now, crosses to Ray. The other mourners watch sideways.

MIKE

Ray.

RAY

Mike.

MIKE

Mama left a box of Beau's things at her place. Darla'll bring it by the house.

RAY
All right.

MIKE
That's all I got.

RAY
It's more'n I figured on.

Mike looks at him a moment. Whatever he came over here to also say, he leaves in the holster.

MIKE
She prayed for you. Up to the end.
I thought you oughta know it cost
her somethin.

He goes back to his people.

The twins approach together. The way they do everything.

TWIN (DARLA)
There's a meal at the church hall,
Daddy.

RAY
I know it.

TWIN (TAMMY)
You comin?

RAY
I'll be along directly.

The twins look at each other. The same look. They know
'directly.'

TWIN (DARLA)
Daddy.

RAY
Go on. Y'all's people are waitin.

TWIN (TAMMY)
You're our people too.

He looks at her. For a second something works in his face
like ground trying to take rain.

RAY
Go on now.

They go.

The PREACHER works his way over, Bible held to his chest like a man carrying a level.

PREACHER

Ray. I'm glad you come.

RAY

Preacher.

PREACHER

Jeanne sat third pew, left side, forty years. I expect you knew that.

RAY

I knew where she sat.

PREACHER

That seat's still there. Sundays. I'm just sayin it exists.

RAY

I appreciate it, preacher. But I believe me and the Lord done settled out of court.

The preacher takes that the way preachers learn to. Touches Ray's shoulder once and moves off among his flock.

Two CASSEROLE WOMEN orbit near. Deciding. The taller one breaks orbit.

CASSEROLE WOMAN

Ray Redwine. You won't remember me. Patsy Click. Jeanne and me canned tomatoes ever August since Carter.

RAY

I remember the tomatoes.

CASSEROLE WOMAN

There's a chicken spaghetti in the blue Pyrex got your name on it at the hall. The blue one. Don't let Darrell Mabry's people walk off with it.

RAY

No ma'am.

She squeezes his forearm and goes. Kindness out here comes in Pyrex or it doesn't come.

EXT. CEMETERY - LATER (2010)

The cars pulling out along the caliche road, dust standing over the fence line.

The canopy coming down. Two MEN with shovels waiting at a respectful distance, smoking.

Ray alone at the grave.

He stands there until the men with the shovels begin to wonder about him. Then past that.

He came in somebody's car. You can see him work that out, there at the edge of the hole.

The wind takes the canopy skirt. The shovel men look at each other.

Ray sets his hat on. Says something to the hole that the wind gets before we do.

Behind him the shovel men give it another minute. Then the first blade-load of dirt goes down with a sound the whole county makes.

He starts walking. Down the caliche road, in the suit, into the flat shimmering distance, a dark vertical the land will have worn down by evening.

A truck slows alongside him. Holds there. Then takes him on -- or doesn't. From this far you can't tell. The dust closes over either way.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - WICHITA FALLS - INTAKE OFFICE - DAY (2025)

Cinderblock painted government cream. A flag. A desk. A box fan working at the heat.

A STAFF MEMBER, 60s, ballcap that says VIETNAM VETERAN, runs a clipboard. His name is EARL DEAN.

Ray across the desk with the duffel at his boot.

And under the duffel strap, half hid, a quilted floral bag. Cloth handles. A woman's bag.

EARL DEAN
Redwine. Like the wine?

RAY
Like the family.

EARL DEAN
Navy?

RAY
'70 to '74.

EARL DEAN
Tonkin?

RAY
Around it.

EARL DEAN
Around it. That's the right answer.
Fellas that was IN it don't say 'in
it' neither.

He works down the clipboard.

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
No alcohol on the grounds. None.
Not in the truck you ain't got, not
in the bag, not in mouthwash form.
We had a fella with the mouthwash.
Smelt like a mint julep ever
evenin.

RAY
I'm done with all that.

EARL DEAN
Uh-huh. Chores rotate Mondays.
Chapel's optional, breakfast ain't.
You miss breakfast, I figure you
for sick or gone and I come lookin
either way.

RAY
What's a man do all day here?

EARL DEAN
Heal up, supposedly. Mostly
dominoes.

Earl Dean flips a page. Reads upside-down practiced.

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
Says here you come out of the
hospital. Says 'family unable to
continue care.' That's a sentence
does a lot of work, ain't it.

RAY
My daughter's got kids in the
house.

EARL DEAN
They mostly do.

He says it without judgment. A man who has processed three
hundred versions of this man.

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
VA's got you for a counselor
Thursdays. You'll go.

RAY
Talkin never fixed nothin I had.

EARL DEAN
Ain't talked to the right fella yet
then. Or done the right talkin. One
or the other.

Earl Dean spins the clipboard. Points at lines. Ray signs.
Signs again.

Earl Dean's eyes go down to the duffel. To the floral bag
under the strap. Stay a half second.

Come back up. Nothing in his face.

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
Laundry's Tuesdays. You got
anything delicate, there's a gentle
cycle. Machine on the left.

A half second of quiet.

RAY
All right.

EARL DEAN
All right.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - HALLWAY/DAY ROOM - DAY (2025)

Earl Dean walks him down the hall. Pointing as they go.

EARL DEAN
Day room. TV gets four channels and
a argument. Kitchen. Coffee's
always on and always terrible.
Chapel, such as it is.

The day room: card tables, a sprung couch, men distributed across it like furniture that moved in.

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
Phone's in the hall. Sign-up sheet
for it Sundays. Some of these
fellas still got somebody answers.

Ray looks at the phone on the wall. The clipboard hanging off it on a string. The names penciled and erased and penciled.

RAY
And if a man's got nobody answers?

EARL DEAN
Then Sundays is real quiet. C'mon.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - DORM - DAY (2025)

Six beds in government rows. Footlockers. A window unit fighting for its life.

Earl Dean leads him down the row.

EARL DEAN
That's Ducharme. Lung stuff. He'll
talk your ear off about the Cowboys
and he's wrong about all of it.

DUCHARME
(from his bunk, not
looking up)
I heard that.

EARL DEAN
That's Otis's bunk. Don't lend Otis
nothin. Not money, not stamps, not
your testimony.

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
And that far one under the window
is Merle. Coast Guard. Merle don't
say much, which around here makes
him the smart one.

MERLE, 70s, lean and neat as a folded shirt, looks up from a paperback western.

Looks at Ray a full second. Looks back down.

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
Yours is the middle. Man that had
it kept it nice, so the bar's set.

RAY
What happened to him.

EARL DEAN
Which.

RAY
The man had this bed.

EARL DEAN
Went to his sister's in Abilene. Or
he went to the VA in Big Spring. I
forget which I tell myself.

He doesn't look back when he says it. Some beds you don't say
true what happened to the last man in em.

Earl Dean goes. Ray sets the duffel on the bed.

Sets the floral bag in the footlocker first, down at the
bottom, and lays the duffel contents over it the way you'd
bank a fire for the night.

DUCHARME
Where you outta?

RAY
Knox City. Lately.

DUCHARME
Lately. Hell, that's all any of us.
Lately.

Ducharme goes back to his TV guide.

Ray strips the bed they made for him and makes it again.
Hospital corners. Blanket tight enough to bounce a quarter.

Fifty years gone and the hands do it without him.

DUCHARME (CONT'D)
(watching over the TV
guide)
Navy man.

RAY
It still show?

DUCHARME
Army'd of left it wrinkled and
called it character.

OTIS materializes at the foot of the bed the way Otis does.
Sixty-some, friendly as a stray.

OTIS
New man. Otis. Say, you wouldn't
have a stamp on you. Forever stamp.
I got a letter goin out.

RAY
Earl Dean told me about you.

OTIS
(unoffended)
Earl Dean tells everbody about me.
It's how come my letters don't go
out.

He drifts off down the row, checking window sills like a man
checking trotlines.

Ray sits on the made bed. The springs take him with a sound
like a gate.

Across the row Merle turns a page.

RAY
Any good?

Merle doesn't look up.

MERLE
I've read it before.

That's all. But it's not nothing.

Ray looks at the window. The lot. The flat country running
out from it forever.

He opens the footlocker once more. Looks at the floral bag
down at the bottom under the shirts.

Shuts it. Sits with his hands on his knees the way the young
vet sits, and catches himself doing it, and quits.

Down the row a man coughs the long cough of a man who will
cough like that the rest of whatever's left.

Somebody's radio finds a gospel station and loses it again.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - DAY ROOM - DAY (2025)

Mid-morning. The four channels arguing on the TV.

Ray at the edge of the room with a styrofoam coffee. Taking
inventory.

DUCHARME argues with a game show like it owes him money.

DUCHARME

BALONEY. It's baloney, you mush-mouth -- B! PICK B!

A man in a wheelchair sleeps with his eyes open by the window.

OTIS works the vending machine with a straightened coat hanger. Patient as a heron.

A YOUNG VET, 30s, sits facing the window. Both feet flat. Both hands flat on his knees. Waiting for a wave that broke years ago.

Ray watches him the longest.

At the card table two men play dominoes with a third chair angled open. The universal sign.

DOMINO MAN

You play forty-two?

RAY

Been known to.

DOMINO MAN

Set down then. Hubert can't bid worth a damn.

HUBERT

That's slander.

DOMINO MAN

It's arithmetic.

Ray sits. They draw bones. The clack of it -- the sound of every domino hall and church basement of his whole life.

He plays a hand. Wins it modest.

Across the room the young vet hasn't moved. Ray's eyes go back to him between plays.

RAY

(low)

What's the story on the window fella?

DOMINO MAN

Reyes? Two tours of somewheres. He's all right of a evenin. Mornins he does his settin.

HUBERT
We all got our settin.

DOMINO MAN
Bid, Hubert.

Ray looks around the room once more. The sprung couch. The taped window. The men.

Whatever he expected to be lower than, this is lower than that.

And he is of it. You can watch him take that on board like freight.

DOMINO MAN (CONT'D)
Your bid, Redwine.

RAY
Thirty-two.

HUBERT
Lord. A optimist.

They play it out. Bones clacking down. Trump called and answered.

DOMINO MAN
Where'd you learn your forty-two?

RAY
Daddy. Back of a feed store in Knox County. Man lost a heifer over a hand one time.

HUBERT
A whole heifer?

RAY
Well. It was a sick heifer.

The table laughs. Even the wheelchair man's eyes come around.

Otis arrives with his vending machine haul. Distributes crackers like a deacon with the plate, dealing himself double.

OTIS
Commissary's open, gentlemen.

DOMINO MAN
Them's stole, Otis.

OTIS
Liberated. There's a difference and
I served for it.

On the window side, the young vet Reyes stands up. Folds his blanket over the chair arm, square. Goes out.

Ray watches him go. The way he checked the doorframe coming through it.

RAY
Down a bone. Who's out?

HUBERT
Story of this whole buildin,
friend.

Ray racks the bones for the next hand. His eyes go back across the room to Reyes by the window.

RAY
(low)
He got people?

DOMINO MAN
Had a wife. She comes Sundays
sometimes. Sits where he's settin
and the two of em look at the same
window and don't say nothin and
then she goes.

RAY
That's somethin.

DOMINO MAN
Out here it's about the most there
is.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - KITCHEN - NIGHT (2025)

Dish rack and government coffee. Ray dries dishes nobody asked him to dry.

Earl Dean counts cans in the pantry with a clicker.

EARL DEAN
Most men your age we get, this is
the last stop. I ain't bein ugly.
It's just the actuary of it.

RAY
You ain't bein ugly.

EARL DEAN
You got people?

RAY
Had a wife. Buried her. Buried my
boy the same year.

EARL DEAN
Daughters, the file says.

Ray folds the towel over the rack. Squares it.

RAY
File says.

The clicker. The cans.

EARL DEAN
Phone sheet's up Sundays.

RAY
I know where it's at.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - DORM - NIGHT (2025)

Lights out but for Merle's book light. The window unit doing
its rounds.

Ducharme's breathing machine sighs down the row. Otis talks
low in his sleep, dealing somebody something.

Ray on his back two beds over. Hands stacked on his chest.

RAY
Any good tonight?

MERLE
Same book.

RAY
How's it end?

MERLE
Fella rides out.

RAY
They all end that way.

MERLE
That's how come I read em.

Quiet. A page turns.

RAY
Coast Guard, Earl Dean said.

MERLE
Thirty-one years.

RAY
Where at?

MERLE
Galveston mostly. Port Arthur.
Sabine Pass.

RAY
Pullin folks out of the water.

MERLE
Some of em.

RAY
How many you figure? Whole career.

The book lowers an inch.

MERLE
Forty-one.

RAY
You got the number right there.

MERLE
You'd have it too.

The book comes back up. A page turns.

RAY
Family?

MERLE
A sister in Conroe. We trade
Christmas cards. Hers is them ones
with the letter inside, all about
her grandkids' ball teams.

RAY
And yours?

MERLE
Mine's a card.

Ray huffs at the ceiling.

RAY
Never married?

A page doesn't turn for a while.

MERLE
Boats was easier.

RAY
Easier'n what?

MERLE
Bid, Redwine.

Which is to say: leave it. Ray leaves it. The window unit fills the space they don't.

The book light clicks off. Then, in the dark:

MERLE (CONT'D)
You don't sleep.

RAY
Not in years.

MERLE
What do you do instead?

RAY
Lay here. Run the books.

MERLE
What books?

RAY
The whole ledger.

MERLE
That's a lot of readin for a man
says he don't sleep.

RAY
I know it by heart. Don't need the
light.

MERLE
Most men, the light's the thing
they can't turn off.

RAY
Mine ain't a light. Mine's a sound.

A page does not turn.

MERLE
What's it sound like.

RAY

A machine. Takin blood out and
puttin it back. Four hours at a
time.

The window unit. The truck out on 287.

The window unit cycles. Somewhere out on 287 a truck banks
through its gears.

MERLE

And how's it come out?

RAY

Short.

A long quiet. Merle's bed creaks. The book light comes back
on.

MERLE

I knew a fella in Galveston ran his
books ever night out loud. Boat
pilot. Got where I could recite his
sins better'n mine.

RAY

What become of him?

MERLE

Retired to Bolivar. Happy as a
clam, last I knew. Turns out they
don't foreclose, them books. You
just carry it and carry it.

RAY

That's a awful sermon.

MERLE

Coast Guard ain't got chaplains
worth a damn.

Ray laughs in the dark. Quiet, so as not to wake the row. The
realest sound he's made in the whole film.

Quiet again. The book light burning its little hole in the
dark.

RAY

Read me some of it.

MERLE

It's the middle.

RAY

I don't care where it's at.

A pause you could drive a truck through.

Then Merle clears his throat. Reads. Gruff and flat, no performance in it, which is its own kind of performance.

MERLE

(reading)

'He came down out of the caprock with the dust behind him standin like a wall, and he did not look back at it. A man could spend his whole life lookin back at weather. It was all still there whether he looked or not.'

The window unit. Otis dealing in his sleep.

MERLE (CONT'D)

(reading)

'He watered the horse at the first tank past the fence line and stood while it drank, and he told the horse they was past the worst of it. He was wrong, but it done the horse good, and sayin it done him good too.'

Merle stops there. Closes the book on a finger.

RAY

That's all right.

MERLE

It's a dollar-fifty western, Redwine.

RAY

I said it's all right.

Merle looks at him a while in the book-light.

MERLE

You want the rest of the chapter or you want to go back to not sleepin.

RAY

Rest of the chapter.

He reads on. His voice finds a kind of rhythm it didn't have at the start, a man who has read to nobody in a long time remembering he is good at it.

Ray lies with his hands stacked on his chest and his eyes open and for the length of a chapter he is not running any books at all.

When the chapter ends Merle marks it with a matchbook and clicks the light to the lowest setting.

MERLE

You was Navy. Where'd they send you.

RAY

WestPac. Tonkin Gulf and back twice. Subic, Yokosuka. Mostly the ocean. The ocean's the same ocean wherever they anchor you in it.

MERLE

You like it.

RAY

I liked the water. I liked bein where my daddy never was. I liked --

He stops.

MERLE

You liked somethin you ain't gonna say.

RAY

I liked who I was out there. For a while. They had a name for me even, the fellas. A good one. Knox City. Made it sound like I come from somewhere.

MERLE

You don't?

RAY

I come from a dot on a map and a man who couldn't look at me. Out there I come from the deck I was standin on. That'll do a young man a world of good, comin from where he stands.

The book light. The window unit. Merle doesn't answer, which is how Merle says he heard it.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - DORM - LATER (2025)

Later still. The book light off for real now.

RAY
(to the dark)
I knew a fella read westerns out
loud. On a ship. Of a night.

Nothing.

RAY (CONT'D)
Forty -- no. Fifty-five years ago.
Lord.

Merle's voice, when it comes, is careful.

MERLE
What become of him?

The window unit. The truck long gone now. The dark with its
one question standing in it.

RAY
I never looked.

MERLE
Why not?

A long time.

RAY
Same reason you read the same book,
I expect. Knowed how I wanted it to
end.

Merle doesn't answer that.

But he doesn't turn over neither. Two old men on their backs
in the government dark, eyes open, the ceiling up there
holding whatever ceilings hold.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - HALLWAY - DAY (2025)

A laminated chart on the wall. CHORES. Names in dry-erase. R.
REDWINE -- FLOORS.

Ray runs a dust mop down the hall, ballcap on, taking the
corners square.

He buffs out a scuff with his boot toe. Steps back. Checks it
against the light.

Earl Dean passes with a box of donated paperbacks.

EARL DEAN
Floor don't gotta pass inspection,
Redwine.

RAY
Ain't doin it for the floor.

Earl Dean looks at the shine running clean to the door.

EARL DEAN
No. I don't reckon you are.

He goes. Ray works the mop on down the hall.

At the laundry room door he stops. Inside, the machines going.

On the folding table, somebody's load done and waiting. He squares the stack without thinking. Edges even, collars down.

A man's hands that learned it somewhere nobody asked about.

He looks at the machine on the left a moment. The gentle cycle one.

Looks down the hall both ways. Old habit. Older than the hall.

Then he goes on with the mop.

Earl Dean's voice from the office door, down the bright hall:

EARL DEAN (CONT'D)
Redwine. You see Thursday on the
board? Counselor.

RAY
I seen it.

EARL DEAN
Seein it and goin to it's two
different chores.

RAY
I'm aware of the distinction.

Earl Dean lets it ride. The door shuts.

There are men who'd see a punishment in all this. He isn't one. The hall shines to the door and it's his doing.

EXT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - PICNIC TABLES - DAY (2025)

Burgers off a propane grill. A dozen men at two tables under a metal awning.

Somebody's radio plays conjunto out a window. Otis deals dominoes between plates.

Earl Dean works the grill in a KISS THE COOK apron nobody has obeyed.

DUCHARME

Redwine. They had chow like this in the Navy?

RAY

Navy chow'd make you weep.

Laughter down the table.

HUBERT

Army fed us somethin in Korea they called Salisbury steak. I been forty years tryin to figure out which part of Salisbury.

OTIS

Y'all hush about it. I'm eatin.

DUCHARME

Salisbury was a town?

HUBERT

Salisbury was a man, I always figured. Owed the Army money.

EARL DEAN

(from the grill)

Salisbury was a place in England, you heathens. I looked it up one time.

HUBERT

Then how'd the steak get to Korea.

EARL DEAN

Same as you did. Boat and bad luck.

Reyes, the young vet, eats at the table end. Present today. Ducharme slides him the ketchup without making anything of it.

Merle across from Ray. Working a burger with a knife and fork, neat as a surgeon.

RAY
You eat a hamburger like it's a
inspection.

MERLE
And you salt yours fore you taste
it.

Ray passes Merle the mustard before Merle asks for it.

Merle takes it. Doesn't remark on it. Uses it.

EARL DEAN
(from the grill)
Who wants the burnt one? And don't
lie, somebody always wants the
burnt one.

RAY
Here.

EARL DEAN
Course. Navy.

The plate comes down the line hand to hand to Ray.

The radio plays. The heat lays itself over the awning like a
dog settling.

DUCHARME
This ain't the worst place I ever
ate.

HUBERT
That's goin on your headstone,
Ducharme.

DUCHARME
Redwine. Tell the ship-fire one. He
ain't heard the ship-fire one.

RAY
It ain't much of a one.

DUCHARME
He does this. Go on.

Ray sets his burger down. Wipes his hands on the paper towel.
A man taking the stage against his will and not entirely.

RAY
Aviation fuel got loose on a tender
out of Subic. We's moored
alongside.

Whole night sky went orange as a
tabby cat and the bosun's standin
there in his skivvies hollerin
about paint. Not the men. The
PAINT. We'd painted that quarter
that mornin.

HUBERT

Anybody lost?

RAY

Not a soul. Four fellas medevaced
and a chief lost his eyebrows. Come
back lookin permanent surprised.
Which on a chief is a improvement.

The table goes up. Otis slaps a domino down out of pure joy.

Ray eats his burnt burger among them. Listening more than
talking. But there. As inside a thing as he's been in fifteen
years.

He catches Merle's eye across the table. The almost-smile
again.

This time Ray is the one who looks away first.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - DORM - NIGHT (2025)

Late. The book light off. The row breathing.

Ray stands between the beds in the dark.

A long time he stands there. A man at the rail of something.

He sits on the edge of Merle's bed.

Puts his hand on Merle's shoulder.

It is not a violent thing nor anything close to one. It is a
hand on a shoulder in the dark. It is fifty-five years old,
that hand.

Merle comes up like a tripped spring. Back to the wall. The
book light on, blinding between them.

MERLE

The hell are you doin.

RAY

Nothin. I was--

MERLE
Get off my rack.

Ray stands up into the light. Getting older by the second.

RAY
Merle--

MERLE
I ain't your fella off the ship.
You understand me? Whatever you
been runnin in your books, I ain't
in em.

Down the row Ducharme stirs. The breathing machine catches
and resumes.

RAY
(barely)
I read it wrong.

MERLE
Yeah.

Merle settles back. Reaches for the light.

And then, quiet, not even mean -- which is worse:

MERLE (CONT'D)
Goodnight, Mary.

The light clicks off.

Ray stands in the dark between the beds. In the middle of the
only world there is.

Nobody sees his face. The film doesn't either.

He stands there past the point where standing means anything.

Then he goes back to his own rack and lies down on top of the
blanket with his boots on and his eyes open and runs the
books till the windows go gray.

INT. BILLY BOB'S TEXAS - FORT WORTH - NIGHT (1980)

The world's biggest honky-tonk, brand new, and every soul in
it twenty-eight and bulletproof.

Ray at the rail with a beer. 28. Boots gone white at the toes
from work.

A FLOWER GIRL works the crowd with a basket of cellophane roses. JEANNE, 26. Quick-eyed. Doing math on every table before she hits it.

She lands on Ray.

JEANNE
Rose for your lady.

RAY
Ain't got one.

JEANNE
Rose for your truck then. Cab could use it, I'd bet money.

RAY
What's wrong with my truck?

JEANNE
Nothin a rose won't fix.

He looks at her. Buys one rose. She makes change out of an apron pocket.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
You got a name?

RAY
Ray.

JEANNE
Ray. Like the rose?

RAY
Like the car.

JEANNE
Mm. One of them's worth more.

She moves off into the crowd before he can decide which one she meant.

Ray stands holding a two-dollar rose in a honky-tonk like a man holding a live wire.

Then, as she's three tables gone:

RAY
(calling)
How much for the basket?

She turns back. Re-does the math on him. Top to bottom.

JEANNE

Basket ain't for sale. Basket's how
I eat.

RAY

Then I reckon I'll keep buyin em
one at a time.

She laughs -- a real one, surprised out of her.

JEANNE

You're gonna go broke a flower at a
time.

RAY

I been broke. This is a better way
to do it.

EXT. BILLY BOB'S TEXAS - PARKING LOT - NIGHT (1980)

Acres of trucks under sodium light. The bass coming through
the wall of the place like a heartbeat in a chest they're
standing in.

Against a pickup, Ray and Jeanne. Her basket on the hood.
Cellophane roses scattered over the windshield like a wedding
nobody planned.

They come apart for air.

JEANNE

I got a shift tomorrow.

RAY

It's tomorrow now.

JEANNE

Then I'm late.

She doesn't go.

She laughs at something that isn't a joke. Just the night
itself.

JEANNE (CONT'D)

Twelve roses you bought. You know
that's a dozen?

RAY

I can count, girl.

JEANNE

A dozen roses, one at a time,
acrost four hours. That's either
the most romantic thing I ever seen
or the slowest.

RAY

I had to think between em.

JEANNE

About what?

RAY

Whether I could afford the next
one.

JEANNE

And?

RAY

Couldn't. Bought it anyhow.

She looks at him under the sodium light. A girl who has been
lied to plenty deciding whether this is that.

JEANNE

Where you from, Ray-like-the-car?

RAY

Knox County. Little place. You'd
miss it blinkin.

JEANNE

What's in Knox County?

RAY

Dirt. My daddy. More dirt.

JEANNE

You goin back to it?

He looks off across the trucks. The interstate humming out
there past the lot.

RAY

Wasn't plannin to. Now I don't
know. Man oughta have somewheres to
bring somebody.

JEANNE

That's awful sure of yourself.

RAY
No ma'am. It's the opposite of
that.

She studies him a while under the buzzing light.

JEANNE
Most men, when they want to seem
like somethin, they get bigger. You
went and got smaller.

RAY
Ain't tryin to seem like nothin.

JEANNE
I know. That's the part'll get you
in trouble with me.

RAY
What trouble.

JEANNE
The kind where I start thinkin
about you when you ain't around. I
hate that. I got a shift and a sick
mama and no time to be thinkin
about a man opens his mouth and
somethin true falls out.

RAY
I'll try and lie more.

JEANNE
You won't. That's the trouble.
That's the whole trouble, right
there.

That's the one that does it. She picks a rose off the
windshield and hands it to him, formal as a deacon.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
Here. On the house.

He takes it like it's the first one anybody ever gave him. It
is.

She gathers her basket. Walks backward two steps toward the
building, watching him, then turns.

JEANNE (CONT'D)
(over her shoulder)
Saturdays I'm at the Stockyards. In
case your truck needs more fixin.

Ray stands among the trucks with his rose.

From everything we know of the next forty-five years, this is the best night of his life. The film lets him have it.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - DAY ROOM - NIGHT (2025)

Late TV. Three men scattered on the couch and chairs.
Dominoes going soft and slow at the card table.

Ray comes in from the dorm hallway and the room reads him in one glance the way drinkers' rooms learn to.

Too straight in the walk. Too careful at the doorframe.

OTIS
(low, to Ducharme)
Aw, no.

Ray produces the bottle from inside his jacket and sets it on the card table in open violation. An announcement. A dare.

DUCHARME
Redwine. Put that up, man. Earl
Dean'll have you out by Tuesday.

RAY
Earl Dean can file me under
whatever letter he wants.

He drinks from it standing. Nobody joins him. That's the loneliest part and he drinks at it harder.

Twenty minutes of television happen in one cut.

The bottle's mostly dead now. Ray up and swaying among the furniture. Arguing with the television. With Otis. With the room. With rooms not present.

RAY (CONT'D)
--and I'll tell you somethin else.
Any man's got somethin to say about
me can say it out loud. OUT LOUD.
To my face. Not in the dark like a
goddamn--

OTIS
Can't nobody touch you, Redwine.
Sit down fore you fall down.

RAY
Touch me again and see. ANY of you.
See what's left of you after.

DUCHARME

Ain't nobody touched you, you old
fool. You been hollerin at the
weather channel.

Ray wheels on him. The room's furniture between them like
terrain.

RAY

You think I don't hear it? Y'all in
here. Talkin. I hear ever word
through them walls.

OTIS

Walls is cinderblock, Ray.

RAY

I HEAR IT.

He turns a slow circle in the middle of the room hunting the
voice in the walls.

The men watch him the way you watch weather you can't do
nothing about.

OTIS

(soft, to nobody)
He ain't hollerin at us.

DUCHARME

I know who he's hollerin at. Same
as all of us. They just ain't in
the room.

And maybe he does. Just not from this building.

Ducharme gets up, slow, palms out. The old-man peace posture.

DUCHARME (CONT'D)

All right. Easy. Let's get you--

He reaches to steady him and that's the match.

Ray swings. Misses Ducharme by a county and takes the lamp
and the card table down with his own weight. Dominoes
everywhere like teeth.

Men up off the couch. The breathing machine alarm going off
down the hall.

They pull him up and he fights them the way a drowning man
fights. Not at them. At everything.

RAY
SAY IT TO MY FACE. SAY IT--

OTIS
Ain't nobody SAID nothin, Ray!

And that's the truth and that's the hell of it.

Earl Dean arrives in a robe with the master keys and a face like weather coming.

Takes one look. The bottle. The table. The dominoes.

EARL DEAN
Aw, Redwine.

Two words. Both of them final.

Down the hall in the dorm doorway, Merle. Watching. A paperback hung at his side, a finger holding his place.

Ray sees him over the men's shoulders.

Whatever was in his throat to holler dies there.

They set him in a chair. He lets them now. An old man in a wrecked room, breathing hard, dressed in the ruins of the only club that would have him.

EXT. WICHITA FALLS - MAIN DRAG - DAY (1970)

A farm truck comes in off the highway slow, a film of caliche dust on it the color of the country it crossed.

It passes a feed store. A Rexall. A recruiting office in a strip of them, a poster in the window: a destroyer cutting blue water. JOIN THE NAVY. SEE THE WORLD.

The truck rolls past it. Stops. Backs up. Parks at the curb in front of it like a man returning to a thing he meant to walk by.

EXT. ARMED FORCES RECRUITING OFFICE - WICHITA FALLS - DAY (1970)

The truck at the curb. Motor running.

RAY, 18, in the passenger seat. Bony. A haircut his mother gave him with the kitchen scissors.

His FATHER, 50s, behind the wheel. Sun-cut face under a sweat-rung hat. Looking straight out the windshield at nothing the windshield holds.

Between Ray's boots on the floorboard, a paper feed sack rolled and folded at the top. Everything he is taking.

Neither of them has said anything since Seymour.

The motor idles. The fan belt sings a little. The father doesn't shut it off. Shutting it off would mean staying, and there's no plan for staying.

The father's thumb works the wheel rim. A man building up to a speech he doesn't have the parts for.

FATHER

Who's gonna pull the west fence
this fall.

RAY

You'll get to it.

FATHER

I'll get to it.

RAY

Or you won't. Fence don't care
either way.

The father almost smiles at that. Doesn't quite spend it.

FATHER

You'll want money for the bus back,
they don't take you.

RAY

They'll take me.

FATHER

They'll take anybody breathin, the
way it's runnin over there. That
ain't the compliment you think.

He reaches across, glove box, takes out a fold of bills held with a rubber band. Sets it on the seat between them. Doesn't hand it. Sets it.

FATHER (CONT'D)

Bus money. And then some.

He says it to the windshield. The boy looks at the money on the seat.

FATHER (CONT'D)

Your mama put forty of it in. Egg money. She didn't say to tell you and I'm tellin you. You spend it on somethin she'd like to hear about. Not whiskey. Not a girl. Somethin you'd put in a letter.

RAY

Yes sir.

FATHER

I mean it. That forty's got her name on it even if it don't.

RAY

I don't need it.

FATHER

I didn't ask did you need it.

Ray looks at the money. Doesn't take it yet. To take it is to agree to come back, and that's its own conversation.

Quiet. The motor idling.

Out the windshield a MAN comes out of the recruiting office with a BOY Ray's age, the boy holding a paper same as Ray's. They shake hands at a sedan, the man and his son, awkward, too long. The man cuffs the boy's shoulder. They get in and drive off.

The father watches the whole of it. Every second.

FATHER (CONT'D)

Truitt's boy.

RAY

I seen him.

FATHER

Army, I heard.

RAY

Navy's farther off.

The father nods slow at that. At the truth inside it neither of them will be unfolding.

A woman goes by on the sidewalk with a parasol against the sun and the father watches her clear out of frame sooner than he'll watch his son.

FATHER

Your granddaddy was Army. Two years in France and forty after of not talkin about it. Died with all of it still in him like a load in a wagon nobody unhitched.

RAY

That what you want for me.

FATHER

I want you to come back able to set at a table. That's the whole of what I want. They don't print it on the poster.

That's the longest thing the man has said in a year and it costs him and he looks out the window to pay for it.

Quiet. Heat shimmering off the hood.

FATHER (CONT'D)

Your mama wouldn't come.

RAY

I know it.

FATHER

She said her piece at the house. She'll be all right by supper.

Neither of them believes that and both of them let it stand.

FATHER (CONT'D)

She wants you to write.

RAY

I'll write.

FATHER

Don't write nothin worries her. Write about the food. Women like to hear they're feedin you somewhere.

RAY

Yes sir.

A long beat. The recruiting office door opens and a RECRUITER leans out, sees the truck, the boy in it, knows the shape of this, ducks back in to give it another minute. He has seen a thousand of these trucks.

The father takes his hat off. Sets it on the seat crown-down. Runs a hand back over his hair. Puts the hat back.

He turns in the seat. First time he has faced the boy square all day.

FATHER

C'mere.

Ray leans. The father reaches and squares the boy's collar with two fingers. It doesn't need it. It is the only thing his hands know how to say.

He holds the collar a second past the squaring. Then lets go.

FATHER (CONT'D)

All right then.

That's the blessing. All of it there'll be.

Ray takes the money now. Puts it in his shirt pocket. The taking and the giving both done without a word more.

He picks up the feed sack. Gets out. Shuts the door soft.

He stands a second by the window like there might be more.

The father looks straight out the windshield. There isn't more. There was never going to be more.

The truck pulls away from the curb before the office door has shut behind the boy. It does not slow at the corner. It does not stop.

Ray stands on the walk with his sack and watches the dust of it hang and settle over the road back toward the country.

Then he turns to the glass. In it, laid over the destroyer and the blue water, the last of his father's truck going small.

The poster behind the reflection. The water behind the truck.

He goes in.

INT. NAVY RECRUITING OFFICE - DAY (1970)

A metal desk. A flag. A RECRUITER, 30s, crisp as new money, a coffee going cold by a stack of forms.

Ray across the desk with his hat literally in his hands.

RECRUITER

Eighteen?

RAY
Last March.

RECRUITER
Finish school?

RAY
Mostly.

RECRUITER
Mostly works. Any police trouble?

RAY
No sir.

RECRUITER
Girl trouble?

RAY
No sir.

RECRUITER
(stamping)
Navy'll fix that.

He spins the form. Taps the line.

RECRUITER (CONT'D)
Why the Navy, son? I got a Marine
across the hall says you look like
a rifleman.

Ray looks at the poster on the wall. The same destroyer. The
same impossible blue.

RAY
I want to see somethin my daddy
ain't.

RECRUITER
Son, you're gonna see somethin
NOBODY's daddy ain't.

Ray signs where the man's finger lands.

Whatever he's leaving, it's signed away by a kid who can't
grow a mustache yet.

The recruiter shakes his hand like closing a gate.

RECRUITER (CONT'D)
Welcome aboard.

He stamps the last form. Slides a little stack across.

RECRUITER (CONT'D)

Bus leaves at six from the
Trailways on Scott. Don't be late
and don't be early enough to think
about it.

RAY

Yes sir.

RECRUITER

And son -- whatever you're leavin,
it'll be right here when you get
back. Towns like this don't lose
nothin. They just hold it for you
till you're sorry.

Ray takes the papers. The man's already onto the next chair.

INT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - INTAKE OFFICE - DAY (2025)

The duffel packed on the floor between them. The floral bag
inside it now where nobody has to see it or say it.

Earl Dean doesn't use the clipboard for this part.

EARL DEAN

It ain't me, Redwine. It's the
rule. And the rule's the only thing
holds this buildin up.

RAY

I know it.

EARL DEAN

Ninety days you can reapply. You
stay clean and you reapply, hear
me? Men do it. Men done it.

RAY

Ninety days.

EARL DEAN

There's a list of beds in town on
that paper. Such as they are.

RAY

I got a place. Motel out home. Man
knows me.

EARL DEAN

Knox City? That's a far piece on a
bicycle.

RAY
I got time.

Earl Dean looks at him. The whole file of him.

Then stands and holds out his hand. Ray shakes it.

EARL DEAN
You was the best floors we ever
had. I want you to know that ain't
nothin.

EXT. VA TRANSITIONAL HOUSING - DAY (2025)

Ray walks the bicycle down the drive. Duffel over the
handlebars.

Hubert and the domino man on the porch bench, where they
always are.

HUBERT
Redwine.

RAY
Hubert.

That's the whole eulogy. Out here that's a long one.

At the dorm window, a shape. Merle. A paperback in his hand,
finger holding his place.

Watching him go.

Ray doesn't look back. And so never knows it.

He swings a leg over at the road and points the bicycle east,
toward Knox City, ninety miles of nothing between here and
there and all of it his.

EXT. NAVAL STATION - PIER - DAY (1970)

A destroyer riding gray and enormous against the pier. Steam
at her stacks. Gulls working the gap between hull and
pilings.

A river of seabags and white caps moves up the gangway.

A bus from the train station unloading more. Mothers and
girls at a barrier waving handkerchiefs like it's a war
movie. For some of these boys it will be.

Ray in the river of it. 18. Seabag on his shoulder. Paperwork in his teeth while he re-grips the bag.

Nobody at the barrier for him. He doesn't look.

A CHIEF at the foot of the brow checks names off a board with a pencil shorter than his thumb.

CHIEF

Name.

RAY

Redwine, Ray E.

CHIEF

(finding it)

Redwine. Deck division. Try not to fall in the water, Redwine, the paperwork's ungodly.

RAY

Yes sir.

CHIEF

Chief. NEXT.

Around him boys from everywhere -- Boston vowels, Georgia drawls, a kid praying in Spanish -- all of them pretending they've done this before.

At the foot of the brow he stops dead.

Looks up at the hull the way you'd look up a cliff. Gray steel running up out of the harbor water into the sky.

SAILOR BEHIND

It ain't gettin smaller, Tex. MOVE.

He moves.

At the top of the brow he stops again -- everyone does, it's the law -- turns aft, and salutes the flag the way they taught him. A beat behind the boy ahead. A beat ahead of the boy after.

And steps off of Texas.

A PETTY OFFICER inside the hatch reads rack assignments off a clipboard at auction speed.

PETTY OFFICER

Redwine. Two compartments down, ladder on your left, rack forty-one. You're under Pittman.

Pittman snores. We've wrote his
mama about it. Nothin can be done.

Ray humps the seabag down a passageway sized for smaller
centuries. Bangs his head once. Learns the height of his next
four years.

He finds rack forty-one in the red dark and sits on it and
the steel of the whole ship hums up through it into him.

Above him Pittman is already a rumor of snoring.

He sets his cap on the little shelf. Squares it to the edge.

Lies back in his clothes and looks at the rack eighteen
inches over his face and does not sleep.

This is the first night of the only years he will ever speak
well of.

EXT. DESTROYER - WEATHER DECK - LATER (1970)

Ray at the lifeline with his seabag still on his shoulder
like he doesn't believe in the berthing yet.

Below, the pier. Beyond it the dry brown country running west
forever toward everything he knows.

A BOATSWAIN'S MATE, all forearms, slaps the lifeline next to
him going past.

BOATSWAIN'S MATE
First ship?

RAY
Yes sir.

BOATSWAIN'S MATE
Don't sir me, I work for a livin.
Where you out of?

RAY
Texas.

BOATSWAIN'S MATE
Which Texas?

RAY
The dirt one.

The boatswain's mate laughs. Moves on down the deck hollering
at somebody else's seabag.

The whistle sounds. Lines come off. The water opens between the steel and the pier, a foot of it, then a fathom, then the whole harbor.

Ray watches the gap grow with his hand on the lifeline.

The pier swings away. The tugs lean on her. The harbor opens out ahead, and past the breakwater the real thing: the gray-green shoulder of the whole Pacific, rolling.

Boys whoop down the deck. Somebody's cap goes in the water to a chorus of grief and laughter.

Ray doesn't whoop. He watches the water come at the bow and break and come again.

Eighteen years old. The most water he has ever seen in his life, and it's the leaving kind.

EXT. DESTROYER - FANTAIL - DAY (1970)

Underway. Land a rumor behind them. The wake running back white toward where Texas used to be.

Ray at the rail, green at the gills, working hard at not being sick in front of the United States Navy.

A SAILOR his age leans on the rail beside him. DALE, 19. Easy in his body like he was born aboard.

DALE

Don't look at the water. Look at the sky and put your feet wide.

Ray does. It helps.

DALE (CONT'D)

My daddy shrimped out of Aransas. You learn it young or you feed the fish.

RAY

Ain't nothin to shrimp where I'm from.

DALE

Where's that?

RAY

Knox City.

DALE

Where the hell's Knox City?

RAY
West of Seymour.

DALE
Where the hell's Seymour?

Ray laughs. Caught off guard by it. His first laugh in weeks and it gets away from him before he can swallow it.

RAY
It's west of nothin. It's all west
of nothin out there.

DALE
And you joined the Navy. A man from
the one place in America ain't got
water.

RAY
That's about the size of it.

DALE
Runnin to or runnin from?

Ray looks at him. Nobody has asked him a true question in
eighteen years.

RAY
Ain't decided.

DALE
Well. You got four years to work it
out.

Dale sticks out his hand.

DALE (CONT'D)
Dale.

RAY
Ray.

They shake. The ship runs on toward the curve of the earth.

Dale produces a paperback western from his back pocket, bent
to the shape of him.

DALE
You read?

RAY
Slow.

DALE

Good. They last longer that way.

He doesn't hand it over. He opens it against the rail and reads where they stand, and after a while, without anything being asked or decided, he reads it out loud.

DALE (CONT'D)

(reading)

'The country he rode into was new to him and yet he knew it. A man knows the place he was made for the way a key knows a lock it ain't met.'

RAY

That's in there?

DALE

Words to that effect. I improve em some.

RAY

Read it like it's wrote.

DALE

Like it's wrote, the fella's horse is named Buttercup. You want Buttercup?

RAY

...Improve it some.

Dale grins and reads on, improving it.

The wake runs back white. The boy from the dirt stands on all that water, listening.

Above them the first evening star where the blue goes off to black. Neither of them knows its name. It has one anyway.

DALE

My granddad named the stars wrong on purpose. Said the right names was for navigators and the wrong ones was for company. Called that one yonder Bertha.

RAY

Bertha.

DALE

After a mule he liked better than most people.

RAY
(looking up)
Evenin, Bertha.

DALE
She don't answer. Mules don't.
That's half what he liked about
her.

The wake. The dark coming up in the east ahead of them. Two boys and a mule-named star and four years of water still to go.

INT. ROOM 7 - EL DORADO MOTEL - NIGHT (2025)

The TV with the sound off. The window unit doing its rounds.

On the nightstand: a spoon, a lighter, a length of rubber.

A pint bottle keeping them company.

Ray on the bed against the headboard.

Gone where it takes him. The TV light washing him like surf.

On the blanket beside him, a little bottle of polish. Coral.

One foot bare.

The toenails done, careful, the cap of the polish still off.

And unfolded on his chest, gone soft as cloth at the creases, a page from some magazine of some decade. A dress. Yellow, full-skirted, nineteen-sixty-something. A woman wearing it looks out at the room from a kinder country.

A knock.

His whole body goes still ... The light-going-by way ...

MOTEL CLERK (O.S.)
Ray? You good? Seen your light.

Ray's eyes come partway back from where they've been.

His hand moves the page face-down. Slow. Even now.

RAY
Good, boss.

MOTEL CLERK (O.S.)
... All right. All right then.

Footsteps off down the breezeway.

Ray's eyes go back to the television.

Static waves coming in.

His lips move.

Whatever he's saying, he's not saying it to this room.

On the nightstand his wallet lies open. Behind the cloudy plastic window: a school photo of the boy, a strip-booth photo of Jeanne laughing, folded edges of others behind those. The whole congregation.

The waves on the TV come in and in.

His eyes go. The polish cap is still off. It will dry out by morning and he will not paint the other foot.

Outside, the window unit. The sign with its dead letters.

The bicycle on its chain.

EXT. DESTROYER - OPEN OCEAN - DAY (1970)

Drills. General quarters bonging through the ship's bones.

A line of sailors hauls hose down the weather deck through shouted orders and spray. Ray among them, soaked through, hands burning on the line.

Doing it wrong. Then doing it less wrong. Then doing it right.

BOATSWAIN'S MATE

THERE he is! Knox City! I'm gonna
make a sailor out of you over your
own dead body!

They two-block the drill and fall out against the bulkhead, blowing like horses.

Dale slides down the steel next to him. Knocks his knee with his own.

DALE

Still ain't decided?

RAY

(getting his wind)
Decided what.

DALE
To or from.

Ray looks out past the lifelines.

An ocean with no edges in any direction. More water than all his people in all their generations ever saw put together.

RAY
To.

Dale nods like a man who had money on it.

DALE
Knew it on the pier. Fellas runnin'
FROM somethin watch the land goin
away. You was watchin' the bow.

The lmc crackles. Some order for somebody else. The ship leans into a long swell and the whole horizon tilts and rights itself like a held breath let go.

DALE (CONT'D)
C'mon, Knox City. Chow line forms
at the rumor of it.

He hauls Ray up by the forearm. Wet canvas and salt and eighteen years old, the both of them, on the biggest thing either ever stood on.

INT. DESTROYER - BERTHING - NIGHT (1970)

Racks three high and men asleep in all of them. The red glow of the night-lights.

The hull works and groans around them. A thing breathing.

Somebody's radio, low as it will go, playing something with steel guitar in it all the way from some American shore.

INT. DESTROYER - BERTHING - EARLIER THAT NIGHT (1970)

The compartment ladder. Ray comes down it off the mid-watch, cold-handed, smelling of salt and wind.

Most racks curtained and breathing. Dale's book light on behind his curtain like a lit tent.

The curtain edge lifts. Dale, propped on an elbow.

DALE
(whisper)
How's the weather up there?

RAY
Comin' up rough. Petrel's still
with us.

DALE
Course he is.

Ray stands between the rack tiers working his cold fingers.
The ship rolls long and slow.
Dale looks at him a moment.
Then shifts over against the bulkhead.
Six inches of mattress bared.
An invitation in a language with no words in it.
Ray looks down the dark compartment. Forty curtained racks.
The red lights.
He gets in.

INT. DESTROYER - BERTHING - NIGHT (1970)

Dale's bunk. Middle tier. Two of them in it.

Dale beside him. Both of them still. Jammed in that narrow
space shoulder to shoulder on their backs like effigies.

Fully clothed. Dungarees and socks.

The paperback is closed on Dale's chest, his finger holding
the place out of habit though it's too dark to read.

DALE
(a whisper)
You awake.

RAY
Yeah.

DALE
Storm petrel followed us all day
today. You see it?

RAY
The little black one?

DALE
Little black one. Walks on the
water, looks like. My daddy said
they're the souls of drowned
sailors. Said you don't never run
one off.

RAY
You believe that?

DALE
I believe he needed it to be
somethin'. Man loses friends to the
water, the water better mean
somethin'.

The hull groans. Forty men breathing in the red dark.

RAY
Dale.

DALE
Yeah.

A long beat.

The radio's steel guitar bending some note all the way over
the curve of the world.

RAY
Nothin'.

DALE
All right.

Neither of them moves.

Forty straight men sleeping within spitting distance.

Dale's hand and Ray's hand on the blanket between them. Near.

Not touching.

DALE (CONT'D)
(barely sound at all)
Whatever it is you didn't say. You
don't got to say it. I been
knowin'.

Ray stares at the rack bottom eighteen inches above his face.

RAY

It ain't -- there's no sayin' it.
Not where I'm from.

DALE

We're a thousand mile from where
you're from.

RAY

A man takes it with him.

Quiet.

DALE

Yeah. I expect he does.

The little finger of Dale's hand moves the last half inch.

Rests against the little finger of Ray's.

That's all. That's everything.

Two fingers side by side on a wool blanket in the red dark.

The hull breathing, and the radio's far shore, and no law of
God or Navy able to name what has or hasn't happened here.

Ray doesn't pull away.

The ship takes a sea on the bow.

Spray rattles down the decks above like thrown gravel.

Neither of them startles.

They ride it the way the ship rides it.

RAY

(whisper)

After. The Navy, I mean. What do
you figure on?

DALE

Daddy's boat, I expect. Aransas.
Mornin's you can see the shrimp
fleet go out all lit up like a town
that floats.

RAY

That'd be somethin' to see.

DALE

Come see it then.

Ray doesn't answer.

A hatch clicks somewhere forward.

Boots on the compartment ladder.

The ROVING WATCH.

A flashlight beam swinging easy down the rack rows, red-filtered, routine as a lighthouse. Both men go stiller than sleep.

The beam walks the racks. Curtain. Curtain. Curtain.

Dale's hand closes over Ray's whole hand and holds it -- not tender now, a grip, a line thrown -- and the two of them lie like dead men while the light passes over the curtain weave and through it.

The boots move on.

The hatch clicks shut.

Forty racks breathe again.

It takes Ray longer than the others.

DALE (CONT'D)
(against his ear, barely)
That's all it ever is. A light goin
by.

RAY
Easy for you.

DALE
Ain't nothin about it easy for me.
I just been in more weather.

The grip eases. Goes back to being two fingers on a blanket.

DALE (CONT'D)
Watch turns over at four.

RAY
I know it.

Neither moves.

The sea holds the ship and the ship holds the men and the men hold still, and for now -- it is enough.

It will have to be. It will have to be for fifty-five years.

INT. DESTROYER - BERTHING - LATER (1970)

The red lights. Ray's rack.

Dale gone to his own, above, the springs of it pressing down with the shape of him.

Ray lies awake with his hand where it was.

Holding the place.

The way you hold a place in a book.

Up the well of the compartment, the watch changes.

EXT. KNOX CITY STREETS - NIGHT - (2025)

Empty streets under sodium light. The town shut down to its bones. Ray on the bicycle, riding the centerline slow.

The scarf at his throat loose and lifting in the night air.

Past the boarded stores. Past the church. The sign out front missing every other letter. Past the school.

A flag on a pole in front of the post office, lit from below, hanging dead still in air that's moving everywhere else.

Somewhere a sprinkler ticks across a lawn nobody waters in the day for shame of the bill.

A police cruiser idles in the Allsup's lot, the only lit thing for a block, the clerk inside laughing at something on his phone.

The night officer in the cruiser lifts two fingers off his coffee.

Ray lifts two off the bars.

He rolls on through the four-way without slowing.

The pedals turn under him easy.

He takes his hands off the bars. Arms out from his sides.

The storefronts give out. Then the houses.

The last streetlight stands at the edge of town where the grid quits and the dark begins. It passes over him slow, head to foot, like a wave going the other way.

He rides out from under it.

And the dark takes him in.